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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' inspecting Udayapur Cement Industry at Jaljale in Triyuga Municipality-6 of Udayapur district on Saturday.

Govt focused to boost agricultural production

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sindhuli, Feb. 3

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the government was focused on increasing production and creating employment by developing the agriculture sector.

Speaking at the inauguration ceremony of Dudhauli Municipal Hospital in Sirthauli of Dudhauli Municipality, Sindhuli on Saturday, Prime Minister stressed on the development of industries based on agriculture.

Stating that he had initiated steps for mechanised agriculture and increased productivity in the agricultural sector during his visits to India and China, Prime Minister Prachanda said that both the countries had expressed commitments for the development of agriculture in Nepal.

He said that the current government was working with a clear vision of good governance, social justice and prosperity. He said that the people-centric actions taken by the government had gained public trust and hope.

Prime Minister Prachanda said, "The government has given special priority to health and education sectors and taken significant steps in favour of good governance. Considering suffering of public, the government has made public service easily accessible to the countrymen."

Stating that as a Prime Minister he had addressed the issues related to the impact of climate change on Nepal in both bilateral and multilateral forums, Prime Minister Prachanda said that he appealed to the international community to help in solving the problems of Nepal, a mountainous country.

He said that important decisions were made to bring country's economy on the right track. He said, "The indicators of the economy are very encouraging, foreign exchange reserves and tourist arrivals have increased. This has helped bring the economy on the right track and revenue has also increased recently."

Prime Minister Prachanda expressed commitment to provide necessary equipment, skilled manpower, and organisational management to DudhauIi Hospital. He said that arrangements for the treatment of snake bite would be made in the hospital as many have died due to snake bite in the area. Emphasizing on the fact that the republic was institutionalised only through the rights of the poor, Dalit and oppressed people, he said that the alternative to the federal democratic republic was a strong and advanced republic.

Complexities of medical equipment procurement in Nepal

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 3

Nepal's healthcare landscape has undergone a significant change, particularly in the realm of medical equipment procurement, since the establishment of federalism. There are multiple challenges and efforts involved in ensuring quality healthcare services across the diverse regions of Nepal.

TRN SPECIAL

According to Dr. Surendra Prasad Chaurasia, Section Chief of the Logistic Management Section at the Department of Health Services, post-federalism, and the three tiers of government – local, provincial, and central – have autonomously allocated and purchased medical equipment based on their specific needs and budgetary constraints. Simultaneously, both government and private hospitals have been engaged in strategic acquisitions, tailoring their purchases to meet distinct operational requirements. "Additionally, a considerable portion of medical equipment has been acquired through donations, a trend particularly pronounced during the unrestrained times of the COVID-19 pandemic," he added.

Dr. Chaurasia informed that the intricate procurement process is initiated with a careful analysis of minimum service standards and the specific equipment requirements articulated by government hospitals. "The Nepal government, guided by comprehensive policies and programmes, allocates budgets for the acquisition of necessary medical equipment. This strategic planning ensures a collaborative approach among the three levels of government, preventing redundancy and optimizing resource allocation," he said.

Collaboration with medical experts, including doctors, nurses, and biomedical engineers, plays a pivotal role in the finalization of medical equipment purchases. This consultative approach ensures a nuanced understanding of the practical needs of healthcare professionals. The engagement of experts also guarantees that the acquired equipment meets the stringent standards set by international organizations, including the US Food and Drug Administration (USFDA) and the European Medicine Agencies.

Given Below are the Details of tools and accessories supplied by the Management Division of Department of Health Service from July 17, 2018 till November 17, 2023

S.N	Equipment Name	Total	Equipment Operated	Delivered and Ready to Use
1	Haemodialysis Machine	333	177	140
2	Mobile Digital X-Ray (DR) Machine	46	45	1
3	Mobile X-ray Machine with Flat Panel Detector System	13	9	4
4	Portable X-Ray Machine (DR system)	10	10	-
5	Fully Automated Haematology Analyser machine	10	10	-
6	Semi-Automated Biochemistry Analyser	10	9	1
7	Portable USG Colour Doppler 3 Probes	14	14	-
8	Portable USG Machine	183	179	4
9	ECG Machine	100	100	-
10	ERCP	1	1	-
11	C-Arm Machine	3	2	1
12	Spiral Endoscope System	2	2	-
13	Ventilator	346	234	91
14	Portable Ventilator	220	139	46
15	ICU Ventilator	90	77	13
16	Neonatal to adult Ventilator	268	210	57
17	Patient Monitor	632	579	13
18	Autoclave Machine 150 Litre	15	7	8
19	ABG Machine	10	9	-
20	Mobile Thermocogulator	99	99	-
21	Anaesthesia workstation	29	18	11

"While commendable efforts have been made to meet the minimum service standards, concerns persist regarding the overall quality of medical equipment," adds Dr. Chaurasia.

The ongoing challenge of delivering efficient medical services is due to the variable quality of the equipment. As technology evolves at a rapid pace, the imperative to update and maintain modern medical equipment becomes paramount for ensuring sustained, high-quality healthcare services.

"Acknowledging the need for continuous improvement, the Nepal government is actively working towards updating the quality of medical equipment. The commitment extends beyond mere acquisitions, emphasizing the importance of simultaneously updating the skills of healthcare professionals to effectively utilize advanced medical technologies. This holistic approach seeks to align the healthcare infrastructure with the evolving landscape of medical science," said Dr. Chaurasia.

While the private healthcare sector significantly contributes to the provision of healthcare services, the affordability of these services remains a challenge. Dr. Chaurasia acknowledged the commendable services provided by the private sector but highlighted the inherent cost implications. Striking a delicate balance between quality and affordability remains a priority for the government in its pursuit of equitable healthcare provision.

Article 35 of the Constitution of

» SEE PAGE 6

PM inspects Udayapur Cement Industry

'Full support of civil servants needed for good governance.'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 3

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has inspected the Udayapur Cement Industry.

He reached Jaljale in Triyuga Municipality-6 of Udayapur district to inspect the structures including industrial plant, informed PM's secretariat in a statement on Saturday.

General Manager of the industry, Khagendra Bahadur Basnet informed the Prime Minister about the overall situation of the industry.

After making an observation of the plants and structures, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the industry should be run by 'upgrading' from the current state. Mentioning that he has taken the problems of the industry seriously, he said that the government is ready to operate the industry with a long-term vision.

The government-run industry was established with the joint investment of Nepal and Japan governments.

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Prachanda pointed out that the current government needed the full support of the civil servants to implement the campaign for good governance.

Speaking at a training programme organised on the occasion of the 16th anniversary of the National Employees Union of Nepal, he said employees' contributions are important in establishing good governance.

Stating that the government had advanced by strengthening campaigns related to good governance, social justice and prosperity, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the government would support the civil servants in their endeavors.

He also expected the employee organisation's support to maintain good governance and impart service to the public.

Federal Parliament to convene from tomorrow

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 3

The Federal Parliament is convening on Monday. President Ramchandra Paudel has, on the recommendation of the government, summoned the meeting of the House of Representatives for February 5.

All necessary preparations for the winter session of the parliament have been completed, said Assistant Spokesperson of the Federal Parliament Secretariat, Dasharath Dhamala. There are currently 24 bills in the federal parliament for the upcoming session. Among them 15 bills are being discussed in the respective parliamentary committees.

Assistant Spokesperson Dhamala said that the upcoming session of the parliament will also see pre-budget discussion.

Currently, there are 88 Nepali Congress members in the 275-member House of Representatives, 78 members of the CPN (UML), 32 members of the CPN (Maoist Center), 21 of the Rastriya Swatantra Party, 14 members of the Rastriya Prajatantra Party, 12 of the



Janata Samajwadi Party Nepal (JSP), 10 of the CPN (Unified Socialist), 6 MPs from the Janamat Party, four from the Loktantrik Samajbadi Party while four from the Nagarik Unmukti party are represented in the lower house.

Likewise, there is one MP each from Nepal Majdoor Kissan Party, Rastriya Janamorcha, Aam Janata Party and two independent MPs represented in the House of Representatives. There is a constitutional provision that the House of Representatives will consist of 275 members, including 165 elected by the electoral system that is first elected from the constituencies established on the basis of geography and population, and 110 elected by the proportional election system.

Revenue-expense gap continues to widen

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 3

Government's fiscal performance remained weak in the first six and a half months of the current Fiscal Year 2023/24 with a gap of about Rs. 79.34 billion in its total receipts and expenditure.

By the end of the first quarter of this fiscal, in mid-October last year, the gap was about Rs. 5 billion.

Despite multiple initiatives and guidelines on effective mobilisation from the Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat to improve the budget performance this year, results are not encouraging.

FM Dr. Mahat had announced a budget of Rs. 1751.31 billion for this year while the revenue estimates were set at Rs. 1422.54 billion which was just about Rs. 19 billion increase in the estimates of the last FY 2022/23. In the last fiscal, the government could collect only 68 per cent of its total revenue target, while a year before in 2021/22, about 90 per cent revenue of the annual target of Rs. 1180.6 billion was mobilised.

However, compared to the last FY, the gap has been narrowed this year.

Government's income-expense status of four years
(up to Feb. 1, Rs. in billion)

Fiscal Year	Receipts	% against Target	Expenses	% against Target	Gap
2023/24	549.76	37.34	629.10	35.92	-79.34
2022/23	519.63	35.63	625.17w	34.88	-105.54
2021/22	625.04	50.39	557.17	34.12	67.87
2020/21	489.63	45.66	464.0	31.47	25.63

SOURCE: FCGO

In the same period last year, there was a gap of 105.54 billion between the receipts and expenses. However, in FY 2021/22 the budget was in surplus by Rs. 67.87 billion and in 2020/21 by Rs. 25.63 billion.

Meanwhile, income of the government has also significantly gone down to 37.34 per cent of the total target in the current year while it was 50.39 per cent two years ago and 45.66 per cent three years ago.

However, government expenditure has remained almost identical in the first six and a half months of the last three years and hovered around 34-36 per cent.

Poor performance in revenue (both in tax and non-tax revenue) mobilisation has caused a problem in financing the development works, including the delayed payment to the contractors. The government is still in the process to clear last year's dues of the contractors.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kaman Dahal Prachanda had to intervene and direct the Finance Ministry to clear the dues as soon as possible. According to the Federation of Contractors Association of Nepal (FCAN), the government has a liability to clear about Rs. 46.3 billion and the process for which has been initiated.

But in terms of utilising the development budget, a slight improvement has been achieved this year with the mobilisation of 19.12 per cent of the capital allocation of Rs. 302 billion. In the past three-four years, capital expenditure was between 15-16 per cent of the annual estimates.

In the past months of this year, the government spent Rs. 57.7 billion for development works and Rs. 90.4 billion (30 per cent of the annual estimates) in loan servicing.

Economists have been saying that the traditional sources of revenue have been drying up and the government needs to find alternative to it.

According to them, the problem will only exacerbate in the future given the transformative nature of economy such as the shifts in the vehicle, and human resource market primarily intervened by the technology and Artificial Intelligence (AI).

FM Dr. Mahat had announced a budget of Rs. 1751.31 billion for this year while the revenue estimates were set at Rs. 1422.54 billion which was just about Rs. 19 billion increase in the estimates of the last FY 2022/23.

Nepal to export cement worth Rs. 150 billion annually

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Feb. 3



The cement and clinker worth Rs. 1.76 billion have been exported from Nepal during the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24. During this period, the overall export of the country decreased by 7.23 per cent.

The overall export decrease was offset to some extent due to the increase in the export of cement and iron steel during the review period.

The goods worth Rs. 74.96 billion have been exported during the review period. The contribution of cement and clinker to the total exports of the country is 2.34 per cent.

The cement and clinker exports have increased by 20 times during the review period as compared to the corresponding period last fiscal year 2022/23.

In the six months of the current year, cement worth Rs. 872 million and clinker worth Rs. 891.2 million have been exported.

During the same period last year, cement and clinker worth Rs. 87 million had been exported. In the last fiscal year 2022/23, cement and clinker worth only Rs. 779 million were exported.

Nepal started exporting cement to India officially in July 2022. It has been only 18 months since the export started. In these 18 months, cement worth more than Rs. 2.53 billion has been exported to the Indian market.

Currently, cement manufacturers, including Palpa Cement, Arghakhanchi Cement and Sarbottam Cement export their products to India.

Government support needed to increase export

President of Cement Manufacturers' Association of Nepal Dhruba Thapa expressed his hope that the speed of export is expected to increase further in the days to come.

The export growth rate of cement has increased significantly in such a short period of time. After the government encouraged the export of domestic goods, the export of cement-clinkers to the Indian market has started to increase, he said.

"Cement is an industry based entirely on domestic raw materials. The export of cement would support the country to reduce the growing trade deficit as it can be exported with huge value addition," he said.

The private sector investing in the cement sector was also excited with the announcement to provide cash incentives in export. The government has also arranged for a cash subsidy of up to 8 per cent to industries exporting domestic goods.

According to Thapa, the businessmen have not yet received the subsidy for export so far even though the government has announced to provide cash subsidy for export.

Around 65 cement industries, including small and big, have an investment of Rs. 300 billion which have a capacity to produce more than 25 million tonnes annually.

Out of 65 industries, about 15 cement industries have been closed due to various reasons. At present, the domestic consumption stands at around 10 million tonnes annually and the remaining 15 million tonnes can be exported.

The demand for cement inside the country has decreased instead of increasing over the years, said Thapa. The demand for cement has dropped to 8 million tonnes yearly at present while it was 10 million tonnes in 2018.

Analysing the capacity of the cement industries operating in the country, Nepal can export cement worth Rs. 150 billion yearly.

"If the government facilitates and takes initiative in a diplomatic way to receive permission from the Indian side for the export of cement produced by other industries, Nepal can gain significant benefit from the export of cement immediately," he said.

He believes that if the government and private sector work together to increase the export of cement in the Indian market, the cement industry will be an important player to reduce Nepal's trade deficit in a short period of time.

OWL FESTIVAL UNDERWAY IN LOPRE

RSS
Myagdi, Feb. 3

The 11th Owl festival has started from Friday in Lopre of Jaljala rural municipality-5, Parbat. The festival is being held at Malika Basic School premises under the joint initiative of Friends of Nature and Natural Heritage Conservation Organisaton.

The festival has been organized with the aim of spreading the message of conservation of birds and wild animals including Owls in the rural areas, said Director of Friends of Nature, Raju Acharya.

The festival has been so far held in ten different districts in Nepal with the aim of conveying the message of conservation of Owl, which is in a critical state due to illegal trade and poaching.

Conservationist Dr Hum Gurung said that Owls has become near-extinct due to felling of large trees, lack of safe food, increasing use of chemical fertilizers and pesticides in agriculture. According to Dr Gurung, 23 species of Owls are found in Nepal and of them nine species are in a state of national vulnerability.

The Owl festival is being held in different districts every year to inform and inspire the community and concerned bodies to protect the endangered species of bird. So far, conservation festivals have been held in Dhading, Chitwan, Nawalparasi, Gorkha, Kapilvastu, Dolakha, Kaski, Khotang, Syangja and Kailali.

It may be noted that the Department of National Parks and Wildlife Conservation and the Forest and Land Conservation Department have implemented a ten-year Owl conservation action plan (2020-2029).

TEA EXHIBITION TO BE HELD AT NARAYANI RIVER BANK

RSS
Chitwan, Feb. 3

An exhibition of Nepali tea is going be held on the banks of Narayani river in Chitwan on coming February 9 and 10. The exhibition is going to be held in collaboration with the National Tea and Coffee Development Board and various organizations working in the tea sector.

The event is being to be organized to promote tea farming, increase consumption of tea produced in the country, inform people about the benefits of drinking tea and to develop a tea drinking culture, said Agriculture Development Officer at the Board Chandra Puri. Earlier, a similar exhibition was held in Butwal.

This is the first time that the exhibition is going to be held in Chitwan and is believed to help production, promotion and marketing of Nepali tea, said Executive Director of the Board Dr Bishnuprasad Bhattarai.

Minister for Agriculture and Livestock Development Dr Beduram Bhusal is scheduled to inaugurate the exhibition.

The Bharatpur Metropolitan City is the promoter of the exhibition while Chamber of Commerce and Industry and the Hoteliers Association are co-organisers.

IFC to invest 56 million US$ in Global IME Bank

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 3

To help increase access to finance for smaller businesses in Nepal, including women-owned firms, and foster climate-friendly projects, IFC is investing US$56 million in Global IME Bank Limited (GIBL).

The aim is to boost competitiveness in the small and medium enterprise (SME) finance market while also improving financial inclusion, creating jobs, and supporting the nation's climate goals.

IFC's largest investment—as well as mobilisation in Nepal's financial sector, will allow GIBL to support the SME segment, helping businesses recover from the impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic, especially women-owned SMEs (WSMEs) and those in rural areas, according to a press statement of the bank.

IFC's funding will also contribute to climate mitigation efforts in Nepal by increasing access to climate finance across several areas, including clean transportation, climate-smart agriculture, and solar projects.

About 50 per cent of the loan proceeds will be earmarked equally between climate and gender financing for the bank's SME and retail clients, read the press statement.

The remaining 50 per cent will be exclusively used for on-lending to SMEs in the country.

This is the first time any development financial institution is providing gender financing to a bank in Nepal. The backbone of Nepal's economy, SMEs generate 22 per cent of GDP and employ almost two million people.

Yet access to finance remains a major constraint for 44 per cent of SMEs with the SME finance gap estimated to be around US$ 3.6 billion.

The situation is worse for WSMEs with 52 per cent of them having limited access to finance.

Additionally, ranked as the 10th most affected country by climate change by the Global Climate Risk Index (2021), climate finance is vital for Nepal's net-zero emissions target by 2045.

Dr. Neelam Dhungana Timsina, Officiating Governor of Nepal Rastra Bank, said that NRB was more than delighted to welcome foreign investment in Nepal. She said that foreign capital is the catalyst for development of Nepal and NRB is ready to extend necessary support in this regard.

Chairman of Global IME Bank Limited Chandra Prasad Dhakal said, "We are delighted to receive continuous strategic support from IFC which is not only giving us strength and confidence but also a mileage to stand tall among peer institutions as well as internationally."

"As the world is increasingly becoming conscious of the impact of business on climate and environment, this loan agreement reinforces our commitment to sustainability through climate and gender financing. Recognising Nepal's potential in the development of green energy, our commitment extends to bridging the resource gap in the energy sector," said Ratna Raj Bajracharya, Chief Executive Officer of Global IME Bank.



PHOTO: TRN

Officials of IFC and Global IME Bank exchanging agreement papers in Kathmandu.

"Furthermore, our initiative aims to confront gender disparity by providing financial support to economically empower women in rural Nepal. We are grateful to partner with IFC in this endeavour," he said. IFC will also help GIBL establish its climate and gender finance business lines while supporting the bank in developing a risk management framework.

"One of IFC's strategic priorities in Nepal is to support financial inclusion and financial sector stability. Accordingly, this investment aims to strengthen the nascent gender and climate finance markets, catalyzing more private sector funding for climate-smart assets and WSMEs," said Martin Holtmann, IFC's Country Manager for Nepal, Bangladesh, and Bhutan.

"IFC's focused allocation aims to empower more women in the country while also creating jobs and boosting climate and economic resilience."

Babacar S. Faye, Resident Representative, IFC Nepal, said that the IFC's investment would help Nepali SMEs to get financing support. This is the third partnership between IFC and GIBL.

In 2022, IFC extended a trade finance facility as part of its Global Trade Finance Programme (GTFP), which included a special provision for green trade financing. At the time, it was IFC's first green trade finance line globally.

Locals block operation of Ratodhunga substation demanding towers relocation

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Myagdi (Beni), Feb. 3



PHOTO: THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA/TRN

Ratodhunga substation

The testing of the substation and transmission line constructed in Malika Rural Municipality-6, Ratodhunga, aimed at expanding the central transmission line in the western part of Myagdi, faced operational challenges due to residents' obstruction despite the positive outcomes of the tests. Following the testing, it is anticipated that the central transmission line's supply and expansion will soon reach settlements in Mangala, Malika, and Dhavalagiri Rural Municipality of the district. This achievement comes after a six-year delay in the construction of the transmission line and substation.

Jaljala Rural Municipality-4 in Parbat has completed a 22 km-long transmission line connecting Malika Ratodhunga from Mohanchowk and a 33-11 KV capacity substation at Ratodhunga. Paddha Sagar Luitel, the representative of the construction company A to Z Engineering, confirmed the success of the transmission line and substation testing under the supervision of the Nepal Electricity Authority's technical team. However, complications arose in charging and operating the substation due to objections from local landowners.

According to Luitel, landowners near the Ratodhunga substation demanded the relocation of five towers of the 33-11 KV transmission line. They refused to allow connections to the 11 KV distribution line leading to Tatopani and Darwang.

Beg Prasad Garbuja, Chairman of Malika Rural Municipality, assured that discussions amid the project management, builders, and affected landowners are underway to address the demands of the locals. Following the relocation of five towers to a suitable location, the substation will be charged and made operational.

The substation and transmission line, contracted by A to Z Engineering through the Nepal Electricity Authority in 2016, were originally scheduled for completion by December 2018. However, the project faced delays in land acquisition, followed by builder's negligence, and obstruction by landowners in pole erection and wire pulling.

Resham Bahadur Jugjaali, Minister of Physical Infrastructure Development and Transport Management of the Gandaki Province, intervened, coordinating with the Ministry of Energy and the Nepal Electricity Authority to resume the work.

The extended delay in completing the substation and transmission line, which should have concluded four years ago, impacted the expansion of the central transmission line and power supply in Mangala, Malika, and Dhavalagiri Rural Municipality in the western region of Myagdi. Pratap Baral, Head of the Myagdi Distribution Centre at the Nepal Electricity Authority, expressed optimism that the operation of the Ratodhunga substation and transmission line would facilitate the expansion of power supply in the western region.

Preparations intensified for Sauraha Food Festival starting on Feb. 11

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Chitwan, Feb. 3

The preparations for the Sauraha Food Festival, established as the Chitwan brand of the tourism sector, have been intensified. The tourism entrepreneurs of Sauraha, Chitwan, the country's major tourist destination, have expedited the preparations for the 18th edition of Sauraha Food Festival 2024.

The Restaurant and Bar Association Nepal (REBAN) Sauraha, Chitwan is going to organise the festival in the main market of Sauraha from February 11 to 15, said Surya Bahadur Rimal, coordinator of the festival. "The activities of the festival have been carried forward to bring back the tourism of Sauraha to its original state," he said.

It is believed that the festival will help to develop tourism of Chitwan as a whole, to promote the traditional and local, indigenous and foreign food of various ethnic groups, and to revive the local art culture and costumes, said Rimal at a press conference organised Saturday.

Dhruba Giri, president of REBAN, Sauraha, said that the festival is being held here every year on the occasion of Valentine's Day with the aim of supporting Chitwan's tourism. He said preparations are being made to make the festival special by taking it forward with food, music and culture.

Stating that Sauraha Food Festival has its own glorious history, he said that Food Festival, which is being organised with the aim of promoting tourism in Chitwan including Sauraha, is contributing to the overall tourism development of the district.

Giri said that the tourism promotion activities conducted at the festival will help in attracting tourists for a long time. He said that the festival has been achieving relative success with the help and support of the organisations involved in the tourism business in the region and the local community in uncomfortable situations such as armed conflict, strike and earthquake and COVID-9 pandemic.

After the COVID-19 pandemic, the tourism of Chitwan, including Sauraha, is returning to normalcy. In the fiscal year 2022/23, about 300,000 tourists visited Chitwan National Park.

According to statistics, about 150,000 tourists have visited the National Park so far of the current fiscal year.

Suspension bridge over Kamala River open for public use



PHOTO: TRN

A newly constructed suspension bridge over the Kamala River.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhalkebar, Feb. 3

The construction of the suspension bridge over the Kamala River, connecting Dhanusha and Siraha, was open for public use from Saturday.

This 1,501-meter-long and four-feet-wide suspension bridge links Siraha Municipality 13, Malhaniyan, and Janaknandini Rural Municipality 6, Dhanusha. Vinod Kumar Mandal, the engineer responsible for the project, proudly asserted that the Kamala River suspension bridge is now the longest in the country.

He noted that the 1,453 metres long Dodhara Chadani swing on the Mahakali River previously held the record of being the longest suspension bridge.

The contract for the bridge was awarded to Thani Nirman Seva Kathmandu, and the federal government financed its construction for Rs. 280 million. Initiated on October 1, 2022, with an initial deadline set for the end of June 2024, the project concluded in January, much earlier than anticipated.

Local resident Mukesh Sharma expressed optimism about the bridge's impact on shortening the commuting distance between Janakpur and Siraha, eliminating the need for a 35-kilometer detour via the East-West Highway and Indian roads.

Sharma estimated that approximately five thousand people from both districts would benefit from the bridge daily.

This suspension bridge, conceived as an alternative following the collapse of the long-awaited Kamala Bridge under the Hulaki highway, has proven to be a timely boon for the region.

The completed bridge is expected to not only facilitate daily commuting but also boost the export of local produce. Binde Mukhia, another resident, highlighted the potential for enhanced tourism promotion and business opportunities with the new infrastructure in place.

Provincial hospital of Mahottari successfully conducts an operation of a broken arm

BY NARENDRA KUMAR KARNA
Mahottari, Feb. 3

In a historic milestone for the Provincial Hospital in Jaleshwar of Mahottari, a ground-breaking surgery has been successfully conducted on a broken arm. Dr. Saroj Kumar Bhagat, the hospital's orthopedic surgeon, skilfully performed the surgery, marking a significant advancement in local medical capabilities.

The successful treatment not only signifies a leap in medical expertise but also promises to save time and cost for residents in the area. Local people await an end to the inconvenience of travelling to distant cities like Janakpur, Biratnagar, Dharan, and Kathmandu for essential medical procedures.

Ramchandra Mahato, 45, from Jaleshwar Municipality Ward no. 7, sustained a broken right leg while cutting bamboo leaves. Initially taken to the provincial hospital for urgent treatment, he was referred to Janakpur.

Shyamsundar Mahato, who accompanied Ramchandra during the treatment, shared that the hospital's orthopedic surgeon suggested surgery, providing a more viable option. The procedure involved the placement of two steel rods in Ramchandra's right hand, a decision made with the consent of his family.

Expressing gratitude, Shyamsundar Mahato, voiced his family's happiness, emphasising the convenience and cost-effectiveness of receiving treatment locally.

Post-surgery, Ramchandra Mahato, under the attentive care of medical professionals, expressed his contentment with the easily accessible and affordable treatment provided in his village, extending gratitude to the medical team.

Dr. Saroj Kumar Bhagat detailed the nature of the surgery, addressing comminute fractures of the distal end of the radius.

He highlighted that the hospital's team successfully executed the surgery, marking a significant achievement for Jaleshwar Hospital. Dr. Bhagat acknowledged the contributions of the team, including anesthesia assistant Manoj Yadav, Arjina Sah, staff nurse Guddi Mishra, and others.

Despite being at the hospital for only two months, Dr. Bhagat upgraded the hospital's capability to handle bone, joint, and kidney-related ailments. He pointed out the need for additional equipment, such as C-arm (X-ray machines), to further enhance the hospital's capacity to treat orthopaedic issues effectively.

Sanjeet Pathak, who operates a medicine shop in Jaleshwar, expressed satisfaction with the successful treatment of orthopedic problems at the hospital. He urged the hospital administration to ensure the availability of necessary materials for surgeries, emphasising the cost benefits of local treatment compared to the expense of seeking medical assistance elsewhere.

Free eye camp benefits about 400 people in Tamghas



PHOTO: TRN

Patients went through cataract surgery taking rest at a free eye camp in Gulmi.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tamghas, Feb. 3

Approximately 400 individuals benefitted from a recently conducted free eye camp in Gulmi.

Bir Bahadur Karki from the Eye Treatment Centre reported that a total of 365 people underwent examinations during the camp held at Madane Eye Treatment Centre, Purkot Daha, organised by the District Eye Treatment and Surgical Centre Tamghas, Gulmi, and facilitated by Madane Eye Treatment Centre in collaboration with Madane Rural Municipality.

Moreover, 42 patients, including two individuals with blindness in both eyes, received free cataract surgery.

Over the past two years, all 42 patients who underwent surgery during the camp experienced successful outcomes.

The medical team included Dr. Kriti Joshi, a Senior Ophthalmologist from Lumbini Ophthalmology Study and Research Center, along with a collaborative team of technicians from the District Eye Treatment and Surgical Centre.

This initiative reflects the ongoing commitment of District Eye Treatment and Surgical Center Tamghas, Gulmi to extending eye care services to rural areas, aligning with their practice of conducting camps in partnership with district headquarters.

CALL TO RETURN NEPALI RECRUITS IN RUSSIAN ARMY

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 3

The families of the Nepali recruits in the Russian Army have requested the government to take diplomatic initiative for return of their loved ones. In a press conference held here on Friday, the family members demanded that they be rescued and brought back to the country safely.

Speaking at the event, Tina Ghimire requested the government to create a safe environment for her husband Padam Ghimire to return home. He is reportedly out of contact since the past few months. A permanent resident of Udayapur, Ghimire is a retired Nepali Army personnel and spent around Rs 900,000 to join the Russian Army, according to his family.

Likewise, Sumi Chamling of Ilam requested the government to search for her brother Rajkumar Mukhiya who has been missing since joining the Russian Army. She also shared that Bikram Bhujel and Rajendra Tamang from her village had also joined the Russian army and were not in contact at present.

Chandni Bista of Bhaktapur said that her husband Bibhajan, brother-in-law Nirajan and grandson Lokendra are in contact but wanted them to be returned back to the country.

On the occasion, Suman Rai, who returned home after joining the Russian army, drew the attention of the government to rescue and repatriate the Nepali nationals who have been recruited in the Russian army.

'Wetlands conservation must for biodiversity'

RSS
Dodhara Chandani, Feb. 3

Wetlands which are vital for humans, agriculture and biodiversity, have been receding for lack of adequate conservation efforts of late.

Reasoning that wetlands are not only the significant habitats of a variety of animals and birds but also the lifeline to biodiversity, the conservationists have sought roles from concerned stakeholders to this end.

Chief Conservation Officer at Shuklaphanta National Park, Pramod Bhattarai, stressed that marshlands have significant contribution in availability of water for wildlife, birds and humans, underscoring the need of protection.

"Wetland is connected to the existence of human life.

It is mandatory element in wildlife's habitat as well. Even the economic, social and cultural aspects of human life are determined by wetland", he reminded.

Bhattarai mentioned that some of the communities and wildlife are dependent on swamp areas.

Five per cent territory of the country is covered by swamp area, according to him.

Similarly, Chief of National Trust for Nature Conservation, Shuklaphanta, Laxmi Joshi, said, "There is cultural importance of ponds and wetlands.

Reasoning that wetlands are not only the significant habitats of a variety of animals and birds but also the lifeline to biodiversity, the conservationists have sought roles from concerned stakeholders to this end.

It is connected to human traditions", she explained, sharing it has become a big challenge to protect marshlands.

A forestry student Ritu Joshi stressed, "Marshlands is important to maintain bio-diversity and ecological balance. So it should be protected. Local governments' efforts count much for wetlands conservation."

Wetlands of Kanchanpur are fading gradually due to human encroachment, warranting special attention and engagement from multiple sectors to curb decline, it was shared.

PATIENTS FACE HASSLES AFTER X-RAY MACHINE CONKS OUT AT MUGU HOSPITAL

RSS
Mugu, Feb. 3

Patients have been facing problems for a month after an x-ray machine conked out at Mugu Hospital.

Patients in this remote district of Karnali Province are referred to the Karnali Academy of Health Sciences in Jumla district after the image cassette of the machine stopped functioning, said the Hospital.

The Hospital authority has not been able to repair or replace the machine owing to unreliable electricity supply. Although the management could arrange Rs 250,000 needed to repair the equipment which malfunctioned due to voltage fluctuation, they were not making it operative in fear of voltage fluctuation damaging the machine.

The machine requires 220 volt of electricity supply which the health facility lacks at present, informed said Dr Kamal Dhungana, Officiating Health Service Manager at the District Health Office, Mugu. However, efforts were underway to install electricity transformer within the Hospital premises to address the voltage fluctuation, informed Dhungana.

Patients are forced to travel to Jumla for x-ray facility which is financially and physically taxing for them.

Concrete houses displacing clay houses in Manang

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Manang, Feb. 3

The combination of increased tourism, western cultural influence, and overall development has contributed to the gradual displacement of traditional clay houses in Manang.

Locals attribute the decline of mud houses to practical issues such as water leakage and discomfort during rain. Simultaneously, the pressure to cater to tourists' preferences for modern amenities has fuelled the shift towards concrete structures. Ram Gurung, a young businessman in the area, emphasised the necessity to accommodate tourists in well-equipped facilities. "Providing services in old mud houses is challenging, and tourists prefer modern conveniences," Gurung explained.

Acknowledging the impact of changing weather patterns, Gurung notes that while snowfall remains a constant phenomenon, the increased frequency of rainfall has led to the deterioration of traditional mud houses. Consequently, he opted to embrace modern technology and began constructing concrete houses to combat issues like leaking roofs and structural collapse.

Karmachiring Gurung, a local resident, highlighted the evolving climate conditions as a driving force behind the community's shift toward concrete dwellings. "Previously, Manang experienced only snow, but now with more rain and less snow, building concrete houses becomes an obligation," he states, expressing concern over the fading legacy of traditional houses.

Preserving the historical significance of Manang's iconic houses is paramount for the well-being of future generations. Local authorities, residents, and the government must collaborate in safeguarding these cultural treasures. Raising awareness and active participation at the local level are essential steps toward ensuring the conservation of Manang's rich architectural heritage.



PHOTO: TRN

A glimpse traditional clay houses of Manang.

SDNTC transplants kidneys of 1200 patients till its' establishment

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 3

A milestone achievement has been marked by the Shahid Dharmabhakta National Transplantation Centre (SDNTC) in Bhaktapur as they completed the transplantation of kidneys for 1,200 individuals. Over 11 years since its establishment, the centre, under the leadership of Executive Director Dr. Pukar Chandra Shrestha, has etched its name in history by contributing to the well-being of one thousand two hundred people through kidney transplants.

Dr. Shrestha shared a notable case of a 39-year-old man receiving a kidney from his 34-year-old wife. The success of the centre in facilitating 1,200 kidney transplants within a relatively short timeframe was attributed to the relentless dedication and hard work of the entire staff. Kidney transplantation gained impetus in Nepal in 2008, eliminating the need for patients to travel to countries like India, Singapore, and Thailand for such procedures.

Dr. Shrestha emphasised that the Bhaktapur Transplantation Centre operates within the Bhaktapur Hospital premises, utilising the available space efficiently. In the 11 years since its inception, the centre has accomplished 1,200 kidney transplants and 18 liver transplants, with a remarkable success rate of 99 per cent.

Dr. Shrestha highlighted that in the year 2080, the centre performed liver transplants for 10 individuals, and preparations for an additional two liver transplants are underway in the upcoming week.

A significant breakthrough for the centre was the successful liver transplant sourced from a brain-dead donor in Nepal.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

A fool thinks himself to be wise, but a wise man knows himself to be a fool.
- William Shakespeare

EDITORIAL

Conserve Wetlands

World Wetlands Day is observed every year on February 2 to mark the date of the adoption of the Convention on Wetlands, also known as the Ramsar Convention, an international treaty aimed at promoting the conservation and sustainable use of wetlands worldwide. The slogan for World Wetlands Day 2024 was ' Wetlands and Human Being' which highlights the important role wetlands play in sustaining flora and fauna. Wetlands are essential for a multitude of ecological, social, and economic benefits. They serve as a habitat for diverse wildlife including endangered species and play a crucial role in flood control, groundwater recharge, water purification and climate regulation.

The main purpose of the Day is to raise awareness of the importance of wetlands for people. Wetlands play a crucial role in maintaining biodiversity, providing habitat for various species, regulating water flow, improving water quality, and supporting local communities. The Day serves as an opportunity to focus on the value of wetlands and the need for their intact ecological condition and sustainable management to make our life healthy. It goes without saying that wetlands form the lifeline for both plants and animals.

Wetlands cover only six per cent of the earth but more than 40 per cent of animals and plant species live and breed in them. Wetlands are responsible for flood control, water purification, and water regulation, but sadly they are disappearing at an alarming rate. These vital ecologies are disappearing three times faster than forests. Pollution, discharge of drainage into water resources, fishing, and over-exploitation of natural resources are the activities that have endangered wetlands worldwide. Anthropogenic activities like unplanned urbanisation, pollution, and encroachment of riverbanks and areas covered by lakes and ponds have disturbed the fragile ecosystem of the wetlands in Nepal.

Wetlands in Kathmandu Valley are being polluted at an alarming rate because of human activities like mixing drainage into water bodies and human encroachment. It's a sad fact that rivers in the capital valley are so polluted that they are unable to support aquatic life. Ten wetlands of Nepal are listed as Wetlands of International Importance (Ramsar Sites) with a surface area of 60.561 hectares. Nepal boasts of approximately 242 wetlands covering an area of around 743,500 hectares which is about five per cent of the total land covered by the country. There is a huge diversity in the wetlands of Nepal, ranging from glacial lakes to freshwater rivers and lakes in the lowlands of Tarai. Owing to this, the huge diversity of plants, birds and animal species are found in Nepal which makes Nepal an attractive spot for ecotourism, recreation, bird watching and research activities for visitors from around the world.

Thus, the conservation of wetlands is critical as they provide a habitat for thousands of species of aquatic and terrestrial plants and animals. Nepal's economy is hugely dependent on tourism and tourists primarily visit Nepal to behold its natural beauty and diversity. The glaciers originating from the pristine snow-covered mountain are the primary water source for the country and its neighbours. So to balance the ecosystem, we must conserve our wetlands like rivers, lakes, ponds and marshes. Wetlands make up the sources of water supply, irrigation and biodiversity. The government and general public need to be educated and made proactive in the conservation of wetlands.

Boost Police Morale

PARMESHWAR DEVKOTA

The kicking and fisticuffs between an immigration officer called Chhayanlal Muktan and a police security officer on duty at the Tribhuvan International Airport last Friday has shed light on the bullying attitude of civil servant towards security forces. Civil servants tend to think themselves as superior to other staff just because they are considered permanent government. Because a state hold them in high regard, they should be soft, polite towards the staff and abide by the laws and procedures provisioned for the work, but the government officials must embrace these virtues so as to better serve the public.

Instead, the service of a police officer is so dedicated and vulnerable that s/he may pay the cost of discharging his duty with his job or even life. So, the job differentiation between a civil servant and a policeman can be expressed with the following example.

As two English words 'democracy' and 'demography' sound alike from phonetic point of view, but they are entirely apart semantically. Likewise, the word civil service and police service are both government services, so they look alike. But they are significantly different. When a policeman stands at the gate in the middle of the night discharging his/her duty without winking his eyes in the chilling winter, a civil servant may be found wrapped in the quilt in his comfortable bed.

So, the police, the confident apparatus of the state, are security providers. Their major tasks are controlling crimes, protecting property of the state, giving security to the citizens, enforcing law and order situation in the country. They are also an integral part of the criminal justice. Therefore, the police on duty have every right to check everyone on the path and in every turn and movement.

A present-day police force is well-trained and capable of bearing huge responsibilities, including controlling illegal activities. If you look back, even in the Panchayat era, the police force was almost neglected and was not well established. After the multiparty democracy was established, the Police Reform Commission was formed in 1992, which played a crucial role in modernising the Nepal Police. So, a policeman these days knows his/her duties and responsibilities well. A policeman works for the betterment of the state rather than for the betterment of an individual.

In a democratic country, the major role of a policeman is to establish law and order situation where s/he stands, making the responsibility of police immense, unique and challenging. Therefore, the state should allow police to work without hassle. The Parliament, for its part, should enact laws making police force strong and capable. Too much interrogation and harassment of a policeman for doing his job will discourage him. A policeman who is dutifully fulfilling his responsibilities and living up to the expectation must be placed where he is.

If we want to develop our country, we must boost the morale of Nepal Police and Armed Police Force, because they are the indispensable to maintain law and order as well as normalcy in the country. If the state mechanism devaluates the works they have done in good faith, it will give negative message to the society.

Royal Palace Massacre

Conspiracy Theories Galore



Ritu Raj Subedi

Almost after 23 years, the Royal massacre in which an entire family of king Birendra was wiped out continues to prick the psyche of most Nepalis. The unfortunate occurrence time and again agitates the national politics. When the carnage becomes a subject of public debate, various political and social actors offer their reactions full of invectives and allegations, which further mystify it. Those resorting to the conspiracy theories cannot present credible evidence to back their arguments. The dreadful event had shocked the country at a time when it was gripped by raging Maoist insurgency.

The issue of Royal massacre has again surfaced after former king Gyanendra, for the first time, opened his mouth about it and expressed his ire for misinforming the people. His statement has triggered accusations and counter-accusations. This has also prompted Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda to announce that the government would reinvestigate into the Royal palace massacre that took place in 2001. PM's announcement has aimed to satisfy the masses unsatisfied with the findings of the high-level investigation committee formed by the then government.

Big ploy

A large number of people still believe that there was a big conspiracy behind the killing of Royal family members but their arguments are based on only perceptions and guess lacking substantial proof. On the other hand, the witnesses of the event solely put blame on crown prince Dipendra for the familicide. They said he got violently drunk before frying his parents, brother, sister and close relatives with bullets. The surviving Royal family members, retired military officers, those close to the palace and a significant number of observers think Dipendra caused the biggest mayhem in the history of Nepal's Shah dynasty. The investigation body had also found Dipendra guilty of the Royal tragedy. But this line of argument is not yet accepted by a large section of populace.

Last Saturday (Jan. 26) former king Gyanendra talked about the Royal massacre issue while addressing a function organised to bestow civic felicitation on him. He said that the 2058 B.S. devastating event was terrifying for his family and they did not want to remember it. "Negative sentiments were generated by sowing a cloud of suspicion in the minds of Nepalis through political manipulation. There were fatal attacks on us and our family. Truth always prevails, false never comes out victorious." The deposed monarch further claimed, "We are still carried away by ignorance and deception although there are witnesses alive. This is not only unjust but also unfortunate."

Apparently, Gyanendra sought to clarify the charges levelled against him and his family members. He failed to disclose the names of persons who

> A large number of people still believe that there was a big conspiracy behind the killing of Royal family members but their arguments are based on only perceptions and guess lacking substantial proof.

turned the palace's Friday party into a bloodbath, but indicated that the crown prince was behind it. But why he raised this issue at this time is a matter of inquiry. The Royal massacre is considered to have paved the way for the abolition of 240-year-old monarchy as many had pointed the finger at Gyanendra but no one presented evidence to justify it.

Although there was an outpouring of sympathy for the late patriotic king, a sense of repulsion at the kingship also grew enormously with the end of his family. As the former king Gyanendra imposed his authoritarian rule, the monarchy lost its popularity in Nepali society. This sparked another democratic uprising that eventually uprooted the monarchy. Now some parties and organisations have been engaged in a series of campaigns to restore monarchy and Hindu state in Nepal.

Ripples

Ironically, Gyanendra's remark has sent ripples in the politics, with some leaders overreacting to it. CPN-UML chairman KP Sharma Oli has dismissed the report of the investigation committee that had cited Dipendra's spurned love affairs with Devyani Rana for the mayhem. Dipendra was deeply disappointed after he was denied tying the nuptial knot with her. Oli has said these narratives were concocted, and insisted that the crown prince had no role in it. "How can a man set to be a king destroy his family?" He has also denigrated Gyanendra, stating that he ascended the throne by default. However, Oli did not name the persons who finished off the king's family and relatives. Seemingly, Oli's comments on Gyanendra came in response to the pro-monarchical drive against the current republican, secular and federal set-up. On the other hand, RPP-Nepal chair Kamal Thapa has termed Oli's statement ludicrous.

It appears that who murdered the royal family and why is still shrouded in mystery. And hypotheses and conspiracy theories abound. Following Gyanendra's statements, social media is awash with opinions and comments on the Royal massacre about which a new generation of Nepalis is unknown. Those who see the internal and external hand in the murder provide geopolitical context to interpret it. A senior police officer, who reached the scene immediately after the massacre, claimed that the murderer/s put on masks that looked exactly like Dipendra. Speaking in a YouTube channel, he went on to insist that some powerful foreign intelligence agencies colluded with internal forces to finish the Nepali monarchy and Hindu religion but it is difficult to prove this logic.

(The author is Deputy Executive Editor of this daily.)

Winter Fog Harmful For Pulmonary Patients



Dr. Shyam P Lohani

As winter descends upon us, so does the thick blanket of fog that often engulfs our surroundings. While fog can create a picturesque ambiance, it also poses significant risks to our daily lives. To ensure our safety and well-being during this season, it is crucial to adopt preventive measures that mitigate the hazards associated with winter fog. During winter, the tranquil beauty of foggy mornings can be enchanting. However, for individuals living with respiratory ailments such as Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD) and asthma, winter fog can pose serious health risks.

Winter fog is a common occurrence in many parts of the world during the colder months. While it may create a beautiful, serene atmosphere, it can also have negative effects on our health, particularly our respiratory system. Fog is essentially a cloud that forms at ground level, and it is made up of tiny water droplets. When we breathe in foggy air, these droplets can enter our respiratory system and cause irritation and inflammation. This can lead to respiratory illnesses such as bronchitis, asthma, COPD, and pneumonia.

Risks

COPD is a chronic lung disease that affects millions worldwide, and the combination of cold weather and foggy conditions can exacerbate symptoms and increase the risk of respiratory complications. Asthma is characterised by inflammation and narrowing of the airways, which can cause wheezing, coughing, and difficulty breathing. Winter fog can exacerbate these symptoms, making it harder for people with asthma to breathe. The impact of winter fog on COPD and asthma patients can be devastating. Winter fog is characterised by low visibility and high levels of moisture in the air. These conditions can have a detrimental effect on individuals with COPD and asthma for many reasons.

Poor air quality results when fog traps pollutants close to the ground. This can exacerbate respiratory conditions such as asthma, bronchitis, and COPD. The fine particles in fog can also penetrate deep into the lungs, causing inflammation and respiratory distress. This is particularly concerning in urban areas, where there are higher levels of pollution to begin with.

Foggy weather often leads to increased levels of airborne pollutants, such as particulate matter and allergens. In addition, winter fog often contains high levels of pollutants, such as nitrogen oxides and sulfur dioxide, which can also worsen respiratory symptoms. These pollutants can irritate the airways, triggering inflammation and causing breathing difficulties for respiratory patients. Winter fog can exacerbate these symptoms, making it harder for people with chronic respiratory illnesses to breathe. The main reason why winter fog is dangerous for people with respiratory ailments is that it contains high levels of particulate matter.

> The combination of cold air, increased pollutants, and reduced visibility can worsen symptoms and increase the risk of respiratory complications.

Cold air is known to constrict the airways, making it harder for individuals with chronic respiratory illnesses to breathe. When combined with fog, the moisture in the air can further exacerbate this effect, leading to increased breathlessness and discomfort. Foggy conditions reduce visibility, making it challenging for COPD patients to navigate their surroundings. This can increase the risk of accidents and falls, which can have severe consequences for individuals with compromised lung function.

To minimise the impact of winter fog on COPD patients, it is crucial to adopt preventive measures. The most important is to stay indoors. On days with heavy fog, it is advisable for COPD and asthma patients to stay indoors as much as possible. This reduces exposure to cold air and airborne pollutants, providing a safer environment for their respiratory health.

Installing air purifiers at home can help filter out pollutants and improve indoor air quality. This can significantly reduce the risk of respiratory irritation and exacerbation of respiratory symptoms. When venturing outside, patients with respiratory illnesses should dress warmly and cover their nose and mouth with a scarf or mask. This helps to warm the air before it enters the lungs, reducing the risk of airway constriction.

Measures

Both asthma and COPD patients should ensure they are following their prescribed medication regimen, including inhalers and other prescribed treatments. This helps to manage symptoms and maintain optimal lung function, even during challenging weather conditions. In addition to these precautions, several steps can be taken to reduce the amount of particulate matter and pollutants in the air. For example, reducing the use of wood-burning stoves and fireplaces can help to reduce the amount of particulate matter in the air. Similarly, reducing the use of cars and other vehicles can help to reduce the amount of pollutants in the air.

The combination of cold air, increased pollutants, and reduced visibility can worsen symptoms and increase the risk of respiratory complications. Those patients must be aware of these hazards and take necessary preventive measures to protect their respiratory health. Additionally, public awareness campaigns and healthcare provider guidance can play a vital role in educating the community about the impact of winter fog on respiratory ailments and the importance of taking necessary precautions. By working together, we can ensure a safer and healthier winter for individuals living with COPD and asthma.

(Dr. Lohani is the executive director at the Health Concern. lohanis@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 4, 1974

Vaccination

Baglung, Feb.3: The Baglung Small Pox Eradication Project has so far vaccinated the inhabitants of 2 village panchayats of Galkot region, says RSS.

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P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Promote Bird-watching Tourism

This is in reference to the news story titled *"Kawasoti hosting bird festival on Feb 9, 10"* published in this daily on Feb. 3.

According to the organisers, the festival is going to feature activities such as bird watching, bird identification training, and vulture activity observation, among others.

Nepal is well-placed to earn a good sum of money from bird-watching tourism, considered to be one of the fastest-growing nature-based tourism sectors in the world.

Bird tourism in Nepal continues to attract more and more people from across the world, most of whom have been heavy spending affluent tourists.

Given this, such a tourism has a high potential to bring more foreign currency than many other forms of tourism. What's more, many species of birds come to our river shores, especially in winter to evade extreme cold in their



Kawasoti hosting bird festival on February 9,10

native countries. Our wetlands are another attractions for them. The government should take concrete measures to promote bird-watching tourism.

Nikeesa Neupane Dang

TAILPIECE

A circus owner walked into a bar to see everyone crowded about a table watching a little show. On the table was an upside down pot and a duck tap dancing on it. The circus owner was so impressed that he offered to buy the duck from its owner.

After some wheeling and dealing, they settled for $10,000 for the duck and the pot.

Three days later the circus owner runs back to the bar in anger, "Your duck is a ripoff! I put him on the pot before a whole audience, and he didn't dance a single step!"

"So?" asked the ducks former owner, "Did you light the candle under the pot?"

Chile declares state of emergency over deadly forest fires

AFP
Valparaiso, Chile, Feb. 3



PHOTO: AFP

The blazes are concentrated in Chile's Vina del Mar and Valparaiso tourist regions, where they have ravaged thousands of hectares of forest.

Chilean fire-fighters were battling rapidly expanding wildfires Saturday that officials fear have claimed around 10 lives and are threatening hundreds of homes, prompting the president to declare a state of emergency.

About a dozen fires have been raging since Friday.

The blazes are concentrated in the Vina del Mar and Valparaiso tourist regions, where they have ravaged thousands of hectares of forest, cloaked coastal cities in a dense fog of gray smoke and forced people to flee their homes.

"We have preliminary information that several people have died, around 10," said Sofia Gonzales Cortes, state representative for the central region of Valparaiso.

In the towns of Estrella and Navidad, southwest of the capital, the fires have burned nearly 30 homes, and forced evacuations near the surfing resort of Pichilemu.

"I've never seen anything like it," 63-year-old Yvonne Guzman told AFP. When the flames started to close in on her home in Quilpue, she fled with her elderly mother, only to find themselves trapped in traffic for hours.

"It's very distressing, because we've evacuated the house but we can't move forward. There are all these people trying to get out and who can't move," she said.

On Friday, Chilean President Gabriel Boric decreed "a state of emergency due to catastrophe, in order to have all the necessary resources" to fight the fires.

"All forces are deployed in the fight against the forest fires," he said in a message posted to social media platform X.

Emergency services were set to meet Saturday morning to assess the situation.

Around 7,000 hectares have already been burned in Valparaiso alone, according to CONAF, the Chilean national forest authority, which called the blazes "extreme."

Images filmed by trapped motorists have gone viral online, showing mountains in flames at the end of the famous "Route 68", a road used by thousands of tourists to get to the Pacific coast beaches.

On Friday, authorities closed the road, which links Valparaiso to the capital Santiago, as a huge mushroom cloud of smoke "reduced visibility".

The fires are being driven by a summer heatwave and drought affecting the southern part of South America caused by the El Nino weather phenomenon, as scientists warn that a warming planet has increased the risk of natural disasters such as intense heat and fires.

O'Neill becomes leader of North Ireland's govt

AFP
Northern Ireland, Feb. 3

Michelle O'Neill on Saturday becomes the first nationalist leader of Northern Ireland's government, when the assembly returns after the end of a two-year boycott by the biggest pro-UK party.

The Sinn Fein politician's nomination will be confirmed at a special sitting of the devolved legislature, which will also see the appointment of a deputy first minister and ministers.

Under the 1998 Good Friday or Belfast Agreement that ended three decades of sectarian violence over British rule in Northern Ireland, the first minister and deputy first minister posts are equal.

But the appointment of a Roman Catholic pro-Irish unity first minister in a nation set up as a Protestant-majority state under British rule is hugely symbolic.

It not only reflects Sinn Fein's position as Northern Ireland's biggest party but also shifting demographics, since the island of Ireland was split into two self-governing entities in 1921.

"Bear in mind, partition itself, the establishment of this state, was on the basis of creating an in-built and permanent unionist (pro-UK) majority," Sinn Fein president Mary Lou McDonald said this week.

"That day has gone," she said, adding that with O'Neill in Belfast, and potentially a Sinn Fein-led government in Dublin at the next election, it could drive "a new constitutional dispensation ending partition".

In the immediate term, O'Neill, 47, faces the pressing problem of fixing budgetary constraints and crumbling public services that have sparked widespread industrial disputes in Northern Ireland.

On Monday, O'Neill, who has promised to be "first minister for all", called the restoration of the assembly "a day of optimism" and called for a joint effort to tackle the problems.

O'Neill has been first minister-designate since May 2022, when Sinn Fein became the largest party at elections for the 90-seat assembly, which sets policy in areas such as housing, employment, health, agriculture and the environment.

But she has been unable to take up the role because of a boycott of the assembly by the largest pro-UK unionist party, the DUP, over post-Brexit trading rules for Northern Ireland.

Northern Ireland's border with the Republic of Ireland to the south is the UK's only land border with the European Union but under the 1998 peace deal it needs to be kept open, without infrastructure.

London struck an agreement with Brussels over Northern Ireland -- in addition to its overall Brexit trade deal.

That accord proposed port checks on goods coming to Northern Ireland from mainland Great Britain -- England, Scotland and Wales.

Unionists, though, said that effectively keeping Northern Ireland in the EU single market and customs union, while the rest of the UK was out, risked cutting it adrift from the rest of the UK, and made a united Ireland more likely.

The DUP finally agreed to a deal with London this week, including the lifting of routine GB-NI checks and what it calls the "Irish Sea border", paving the way for Stormont to return.

Hamas deploys police, distributes funds in Gaza

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Feb. 3



PHOTO: AP

Palestinians line up for free food distribution during the ongoing Israeli air and ground offensive in Khan Younis, Gaza Strip, Friday, Feb. 2, 2024.

Hamas has begun deploying police forces and making partial salary payments to some of its civil servants in Gaza City in recent days, resurfacing in areas from which Israel had withdrawn the bulk of its troops a month ago, four residents and a senior official in the militant group said Saturday.

Signs of a Hamas resurgence in the Gaza Strip's largest city underscore the group's resilience despite Israel's deadly air and ground campaign against it over the past four months. Israel has said it's determined to crush Hamas militarily and prevent it from returning to power in Gaza, an enclave it has ruled since 2007.

In recent days, Israeli forces renewed strikes in the western and northwestern parts of Gaza City, including in areas where some of the salary distributions were reported to have taken place.

Four Gaza City residents told The Associated Press that in recent days, uniformed and plainclothes police officers deployed near police headquarters and other government offices, including near Shifa Hospital, the territory's largest. The residents said they saw both the return of civil servants and subsequent Israeli airstrikes near the makeshift offices.

The return of police marks an attempt to reinstate order in the devastated city after Israel withdrew a significant number of troops from northern Gaza last month, a Hamas official told AP, speaking on condition of anonymity because he was not authorized to talk to the media.

The official said the group's leaders had given directions to reestablish order in parts of the north where Israeli forces had withdrawn, including helping prevent the looting of shops and houses abandoned by residents who had heeded repeated Israeli evacuation orders and headed to the southern half of Gaza.

During Israel's ground offensive, many homes and buildings were left half-standing or reduced to piles of scrap, rubble and dust.

Saeed Abdel-Bar, a resident of Gaza City, said a cousin received funds from a makeshift Hamas office near the hospital that was set up to distribute $200 payouts to government employees, including police officers and municipal workers.

Since seizing control of Gaza nearly 17 years ago, Hamas has been operating a government bureaucracy with tens of thousands of civil servants, including teachers, traffic cops and civil police who operate separately from the group's secretive military wing.

The partial salary payments of $200 for at least some government employees signal that Israel has not delivered a knockout blow to Hamas, even as it claims to have killed more than 9,000 Hamas fighters.

Ahmed Abu Hadrous, a Gaza City resident, said Israeli warplanes struck the area where the makeshift office is located multiple times earlier this week, including Saturday morning.

The strikes come roughly a month after Israeli military leaders said they had broken up the command structure of Hamas battalions in the north, but that individual fighters were continuing to carry out guerrilla-style attacks.

Meanwhile, combat continued in southern Gaza on Saturday.

At least 17 people, including women and children, were killed in two separate airstrikes overnight in Gaza's southernmost town of Rafah, on the border with Egypt, according to the registration office at a hospital where the bodies were taken.

The first strike hit a residential building east of Rafah, killing at least 13 people from the Hijazi family. The dead included four women and three children, hospital officials said. The second strike struck a house in the Jeneina area of Rafah, killing at least two men and two women from the Hams family.

US hits hard at militias in Iraq, Yemen

AP
Washington, Feb. 3



FILE PHOTO: AP

Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin speaks during a Pentagon press briefing at the Pentagon on Thursday, Feb. 1, 2024 in Washington.

The U.S. military launched an air assault on dozens of sites in Iraq and Syria used by Iranian-backed militias and the Iranian Revolutionary Guard Friday, in the opening salvo of retaliation for the drone strike that killed three U.S. troops in Jordan last weekend.

The massive barrage of strikes hit more than 85 targets at seven locations, including command and control headquarters, intelligence centres, rockets and missiles, drone and ammunition storage sites and other facilities that were connected to the militias or the IRGC's Quds Force, the Guard's expeditionary unit that handles Tehran's relationship with and arming of regional militias. And President Joe Biden made it clear in a statement that there will be more to come.

The U.S. strikes appeared to stop short of directly targeting Iran or senior leaders of the Revolutionary Guard Quds Force within its borders, as the U.S. tries to prevent the conflict from escalating even further. Iran has denied it was behind the Jordan attack.

It was unclear what the impact will be of the strikes. Days of U.S. warnings may have sent militia members scattering into hiding. With multiple groups operating at various locations in several countries, a knockout blow is unlikely.

Though one of the main Iran-backed militias, Kataib Hezbollah, said it was suspending attacks on American troops, others have vowed to continue fighting, casting themselves as champions of the Palestinian cause while the war in Gaza shows no sign of ending.

"Our response began today. It will continue at times and places of our choosing," Biden warned, adding, "let all those who might seek to do us harm know this: If you harm an American, we will respond." He and other top U.S. leaders had been saying for days that any American response wouldn't be just one hit but a "tiered response" over time.

National Security Council spokesman John Kirby said the targets "were carefully selected to avoid civilian casualties and based on clear, irrefutable evidence that they were connected to attacks on U.S. personnel in the region." He declined to detail what that evidence was.

The strikes took place over about 30 minutes, and three of the sites struck were in Iraq and four were in Syria, said Lt. Gen. Douglas Sims, director of the Joint Staff.

U.S. Central Command said the assault involved more than 125 precision munitions, and they were delivered by numerous aircraft, including long-range B-1 bombers flown from the United States. Sims said weather was a factor as the U.S. planned the strikes in order to allow the U.S. to confirm it was hitting the right targets and avoiding civilian casualties.

It's not clear, however, whether militia members were killed.

"We know that there are militants that use these locations, IRGC as well as Iranian-aligned militia group personnel," Sims said. "We made these strikes tonight with an idea that there there would likely be casualties associated with people inside those facilities."

PRISM

Gear shift knob from snake's stomach

Maryland: Veterinarians in Maryland performed surgery on a rat snake to remove a gear shift knob the serpent had mistakenly swallowed.

The Second Chance Wildlife Center in Gaithersburg said the snake was brought in with an unknown foreign object in its stomach.

"This is common in rat snakes, as golf balls and decoy eggs are often mistaken for fresh chicken eggs," the center said in an Instagram post. "In this case, the object had been trapped in the snake's stomach so long that there was a hole worn through the snake's skin."

The object was surgically removed from inside the snake and identified as a gear shift knob from a car.

The post said the snake has now made a full recovery and will be released in the spring.

Unclaimed emu gets new sanctuary home

Washington: An emu found wandering loose in Washington has a new home at a sanctuary after no owner came forward to claim the large Australian bird.

The Kitsap Humane Society said the emu, nicknamed Elliot, was captured last week with help from the Washington State Patrol, the Kitsap County Sheriff's Office and the Washington State Department of Transportation. The emu was taken to a barn temporarily while investigators tried to find its owner.

The flightless bird went unclaimed for more than 72 hours, leading the humane society to find it a new permanent home at the Center Valley Animal Rescue.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

211 – Following the death of the Roman Emperor Septimius Severus at Eboracum (modern York, England) while preparing to lead a campaign against the Caledonians, the empire is left in the control of his two quarrelling sons, Caracalla and Geta, whom he had instructed to make peace.

960 – Zhao Kuangyin declares himself Emperor Taizu of Song, ending the Later Zhou and beginning the Song dynasty.

1555 – John Rogers is burned at the stake, becoming the first English Protestant martyr under Mary I of England.

1703 – In Edo (now Tokyo), all but one of the Forty-seven Ronin commit seppuku (ritual suicide) as recompense for avenging their master's death.

1758 – The city of Macapá in Brazil is founded by Sebastião Veiga Cabral.

1899 – The Philippine–American War begins when four Filipino soldiers enter the "American Zone" in Manila, igniting the Battle of Manila.

Rain-scrambled parade scheduled in New Orleans

AP
New Orleans, Feb. 3



FILE PHOTO: AP

Member of the Mystic Krewe of Femme Fatale have fun with the crowd as the Krewe of Nefertiti rolls along Lake Forest Blvd. in New Orleans East, Sunday, Jan. 28, 2024.

New Orleans' annual Carnival celebration entered its high-intensity home stretch Friday with a beefed-up police presence and a weather forecast that threatened to disrupt the first of two weekends of elaborate parades.

Three parades were scheduled to roll Friday night with no weather complications expected. But flood-threatening rains were in the forecast for Saturday. City officials and organizers of six parades scheduled to roll Saturday were changing start times in hopes of avoiding the deluges. Five parade step-off times were moved up, and another parade was rescheduled for Sunday.

"We can move some times back and forth. We will thread the needle with these parades," Collin Arnold, the city's homeland security director, said during a news conference earlier in the week.

In neighbouring Jefferson Parish, the Mad Hatters parade also was moved from Saturday to Sunday.

Carnival season started Jan. 6 and ends on Mardi Gras — Fat Tuesday — which falls this year on Feb. 13. The final two weekends are marked by elaborate processions on St. Charles Avenue.

Because of the rain threat, the first of six processions, which typically feature marching bands and floats carrying masked riders, was to kick off Saturday at 9:30 a.m., instead of midday. And parade organizations were mulling cutbacks in the number of participants. The Krewe of Sparta parade, the last parade scheduled for the day, planned to roll with floats only, in hopes of wrapping up before the rain arrives.

The New Orleans Police Department, which has been making do with a diminished force of about 900 for several years, will be joined by more than 100 state troopers, 170 Orleans Parish Sheriff's Department deputies and more than 200 deputies from other Louisiana jurisdictions.

OLI VOWS PROTECTION OF NATIONAL INTEREST

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 4

Chairperson of the CPN (UML) KP Sharma Oli has stressed that his party would play a responsible role to protect national interest.

Addressing the meeting of UML parliamentary party on Saturday, Chair Oli mentioned that the role of opposition party is significant to make parliamentary practice effective.

On the occasion, he directed the lawmakers of the party to speak out against anomalies seen in the country and to present themselves firmly.

Pointing out the need of strong and effective role of the opposition in the parliament, the UML Chair urged the lawmakers to be present in a considerate manner.

He mentioned, "Lawmakers should run the parliament and committee meetings in a systematic manner, make it further active, and hold much discussion."

121-YEAR-OLD WOMAN DIES

RSS
Nuwakot, Feb 4

A 121-year-old woman at Kakani Rural Municipality-8 in Nuwakot district passed away.

Batuli Lamichhane, who was suffering from respiratory illnesses for the past one week, died at her home on Friday, Lamichhane's relative Uddhav Humagain said.

Lamichhane was receiving health care services at her home with support from the rural municipality and Bala Foundation.

A family source said that Lamichhane's final rites were performed at Pashupati Aryaghat on Friday night. Batuli's son Netra Prasad Lamichhane, 82, lit the funeral pyre of his mother.

As per the official record, Lamichhane was born in 1959 BS.



PHOTO COURTESY: EMBASSY OF INDIA, KATHMANDU

A delegation of Nepal's Parliamentary Committee on International Relations and Tourism led by its chair Raj Kishor Yadav met Rohan Khaunte, the Tourism Minister of Goa, India and discussed greater cultural exchanges and tourist flow between Goa and Nepal.

South Africa rush to register 100,000 prisoners to vote

AP
Pretoia, Feb. 4

South African election officials have visited prisons across the country as part of an ambitious project to register at least 100,000 inmates to vote in this year's national election.

The country's constitution guarantees every adult citizen the right to vote — meaning there are no restrictions on prisoners taking part in elections, a stark contrast to most other African nations. The date for the vote has not yet been announced, but it's expected to be held between May and August.

The Electoral Commission of South Africa hopes to register a record number of inmates in the 240 correctional facilities across the country as voters. Around 15,000 prisoners voted in the last national election in 2019.

South Africa has about 157,000 inmates currently in prison, according to authorities. The country struggles with one of the highest crime rates in the world.

The commission said that though it was concluding its visit to all 240 prisons by the end of Thursday, it still could not say how many prisoners countrywide had registered.

At the all-male Zonderwater Correctional Centre on the outskirts of the capital, Pretoria, prisoners in orange uniforms lined up Thursday in a hall to register as first-time voters or update their details on electoral rolls if they have been recently incarcerated.

Guards kept a close watch. A banner with the words "Ensuring Free and Fair Elections" was pinned to a prison wall.

Other inmates ignored the process, chatting to each other or getting on with their work preparing lunch in the cafeteria.

"The whole country is a single constituency," said electoral commission chairperson Mosotho Moepya. "Whether they are here at Zonderwater … or elsewhere in the country."

Khathutshelo Mashau, an inmate who registered, said he thinks that prisoners also have an interest in who governs the country.

"The way our courts are operating sometimes, it does frustrate us," Mashau said. "If you are writing an appeal it takes so long. That's one thing that us, as offenders, we are worried about."

Mandla Mpangane also registered to vote but said most prisoners did not, largely because they are disillusioned with the way the legal process handles their parole applications and grievances while in prison.

He said he hoped his vote would improve the running of the prison and life for his family on the outside.

"It will make a big difference in our community," he said.

South Africa, with a population of 62 million, has more than 27 million registered voters so far for this year's national election.

It will be South Africa's seventh under its new democracy. The country's first all-race vote was held in 1994 and saw Nelson Mandela elected as the country's first Black president to officially end the apartheid system of forced racial segregation.

The African National Congress party once led by Mandela has been in government ever since apartheid ended.

Hamas shows signs of resurgence in parts of Gaza

AP
Rafah, Feb. 4

Hamas has begun to resurface in areas where Israel withdrew the bulk of its forces a month ago, deploying police officers and making partial salary payments to some of its civil servants in Gaza City in recent days, four residents and a senior official in the militant group said Saturday.

Signs of a Hamas resurgence in Gaza's largest city underscore the group's resilience despite Israel's deadly air and ground campaign over the past four months. Israel has said it's determined to crush Hamas and prevent it from returning to power in Gaza, an enclave it has ruled since 2007.

In recent days, Israeli forces renewed strikes in the western and northwestern parts of Gaza City, including in areas where some of the salary distributions were reported to have taken place.

Four Gaza City residents told The Associated Press that in recent days, uniformed and plainclothes police officers deployed near police headquarters and other government offices, including near Shifa Hospital, the territory's largest. The residents said they saw the return of civil servants and subsequent Israeli airstrikes near the makeshift offices.

The return of police marks an attempt to reinstate order in the devastated city after Israel withdrew a significant number of troops from northern Gaza last month, a Hamas official told AP, speaking on condition of anonymity because he was not authorized to talk to the media.

The official said the group's leaders had given directions to reestablish order in parts of the north where Israeli forces had withdrawn, including by helping prevent the looting of shops and houses abandoned by residents who had heeded repeated Israeli evacuation orders and headed to the southern half of Gaza.

During Israel's ground offensive, many homes and buildings were left half-standing or reduced to piles of scrap, rubble and dust.

Saeed Abdel-Bar, a resident of Gaza City, said a cousin received funds from a makeshift Hamas office near the hospital that was set up to distribute $200 payouts to government employees, including police officers and municipal workers.

Since seizing control of Gaza nearly 17 years ago, Hamas has been operating a government bureaucracy with tens of thousands of civil servants, including teachers, traffic cops and civil police who operate separately from the group's secretive military wing.

The partial salary payments of $200 for at least some government employees signal that Israel has not delivered a knockout blow to Hamas, even as it claims to have killed more than 9,000 Hamas fighters.

Ahmed Abu Hadrous, a Gaza City resident, said Israeli warplanes struck the area where the makeshift office is located multiple times earlier this week, including Saturday morning.

The strikes come roughly a month after Israeli military leaders said they had broken up the command structure of Hamas battalions in the north, but that individual fighters were continuing to carry out guerrilla-style attacks.

Meanwhile, combat continued in southern Gaza on Saturday.

At least 11 people were injured when Israel's military fired smoke bombs at displaced people sheltering at the headquarters of the Palestinian Red Crescent in the southern city of Khan Younis, the organization said. It didn't elaborate, and the Israeli military had no immediate comment.

The injuries followed a siege that the Israeli military has laid on the Red Crescent's facilities for 12 days, the organization said.

The charity also said it documented the killing of 43 people, including three staff members, inside the buildings by Israeli fire in those 12 days. Another 153 were injured, it said.

At least 17 people, including women and children, were killed in two separate airstrikes overnight in Gaza's southernmost town of Rafah, on the border with Egypt, according to the registration office at a hospital where the bodies were taken.

The first strike hit a residential building east of Rafah, killing at least 13 people from the Hijazi family. The dead included four women and three children, hospital officials said.

The second strike struck a house in the Jeneina area of Rafah, killing at least two men and two women from the Hams family.

"Two children are still under the rubble, and we don't, still we don't know anything about them," relative Ahmad Hijazi said.

The 17 bodies were taken to the Abu Yousef al-Najjar hospital, the main health facility in Rafah, and were seen by an AP journalist. The Health Ministry in Gaza said Saturday that 107 people were killed over the preceding 24-hour period, bringing the wartime total to 27,238. More than 66,000 people have been wounded.

'UN's top court has jurisdiction in part of Ukraine's genocide case against Russia'

AP
The Hague, Feb. 4

The United Nations' top court said Friday it has jurisdiction to rule on a request by Ukraine for a declaration that Kyiv is not responsible for genocide, but not on other aspects of a Ukrainian case against Russia.

The two countries have at various times accused each other of committing genocide. Ukraine filed its case at the International Court of Justice just days after Russia's February 2022 invasion, alleging that Moscow used trumped-up claims of genocide to justify its attack that unleashed Europe's biggest conflict since World War II.

But the court said it could not rule on that issue. Instead, it will rule on whether Ukraine violated the convention — as Russian President Vladimir Putin claimed to justify the invasion. A final, legally binding decision is likely still years away.

"In the present case, even if the Russian Federation had, in bad faith, alleged that Ukraine committed genocide and taken certain measures against it under such a pretext, which the respondent (Ukraine) contends, this would not in itself constitute a violation of obligations" under the genocide convention, the court's President Joan E. Donoghue said.

The court said it did not have jurisdiction to rule on whether Russia's invasion violated the 1948 genocide convention and whether Moscow's recognition of two breakaway republics in eastern Ukraine also amounted to a breach of the convention. Despite those setbacks, Ukraine hailed the ruling as a victory that will allow the case to continue.

"It is important that the court will decide on the issue that Ukraine is not responsible for some mythical genocide, which the Russian Federation falsely alleged that Ukraine has committed," the leader of Ukraine's legal team, Anton Korynevych, told reporters.

He also welcomed the fact that a preliminary order by the court that Russia immediately halt its invasion remains in place — even though Moscow has flouted it. Russian officials left the court without commenting.

Melanie O'Brien, president of the International Association of Genocide Scholars, told The Associated Press in an email that the court "decided that it cannot adjudicate on Russia's use of force — that is, its invasion of Ukraine — because even though this use of force may be a violation of international law, which prohibits the use of force except in self-defence or under a UN-mandated operation, it is a not a rule that exists under the Genocide Convention."

She said the decision could mean "that Ukraine may bring another case before the ICJ, this time under the UN Charter, which prohibits the unlawful use of force by states against other states."

Moscow argued last year that the court should throw out the case before even considering the merits of Kyiv's claims, but the 16-judge panel will now go ahead.

At hearings in September, the leader of Moscow's legal team, Gennady Kuzmin, called Ukraine's case "hopelessly flawed and at odds with the longstanding jurisprudence of this court."

A member of Moscow's legal team, Sienho Yee, told judges in September that Russia had not used the genocide convention to justify its military actions in Ukraine, saying they "are based on the right to self-determination and its inherent right to self-defense."



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

An artist sculpting idol at Nagbahal in Lalitpur district.

Tackling complexities of medical...

Nepal enshrines the right of every citizen to access to free basic health services from the state. However, challenges persist in fulfilling these constitutional rights due to a myriad of factors, including equipment quality, the availability of skilled healthcare professionals, and limitations in healthcare infrastructure.

The Policy and Action Plan 2023/24 outlines pivotal initiatives to enhance healthcare services, including ensuring essential medical personnel, equipping hospitals with state-of-the-art diagnostic tools, and establishing specialized healthcare facilities. These policies are a testament to the government's commitment to providing quality healthcare services to its citizens.

There are various challenges in purchasing of apparatus including equipment non-operation, the need for streamlined procurement procedures, and the absence of standardized criteria for acquiring medical equipment. Ongoing efforts to address these challenges involve institutionalising procurement information systems, enhancing contract management, and building capacity in procurement and supply management.

"To overcome the multifaceted challenges in healthcare equipment procurement, there should be an advocacy for policy reforms. Proposals include introducing a dedicated section for the procurement of health supplies in the Public Procurement Act, ensuring consistency in quality and pricing through centralized bidding, and formulating regulations for national quality standards," said Dr. Chaurasia.

There should be vigorous initiatives and the areas that demand attention to build a resilient and efficient healthcare system. Addressing these challenges is not only imperative for enhancing the healthcare system but also for ensuring that the constitutional rights of citizens to quality healthcare are not just aspirations but tangible realities. The journey towards a robust and inclusive healthcare system in Nepal is ongoing, and the insights provided serve as a compass guiding the nation towards a better healthier future.

NKorea says it tested cruise missiles with warheads

AP
Seol, Feb. 4

North Korea said it tested cruise missiles outfitted with new "super-large" warheads as well as a new type of anti-aircraft missile, extending a streak in weapons demonstrations that has rival South Korea worried.

The report Saturday by North Korean state media came a day after South Korea's military said it detected the North launching multiple cruise missiles into waters off its western coast. It's the country's fourth round of launches of such weapons in 2024.

North Korean photos of the test showed a low-flying cruise missile striking a target built on a coastal shore, and another projectile soaring into the air after being launched from ground.

In announcing the development of larger warheads for cruise missiles, North Korea could be trying to emphasize that these missiles are intended to be armed with nuclear weapons.

North Korea's official Korean Central News Agency did not specify the number of missiles tested or the details of their performance. The agency said the tests were part of the country's "normal activities" for military development and did not affect the security of neighbors.

Cruise missiles are among a growing collection of North Korean weapons designed to overwhelm regional missile defenses. They supplement the country's vast lineup of ballistic missiles, including long-range weapons aimed at the continental United States.

Analysts say anti-aircraft missile technology is an area where North Korea could benefit from its deepening military cooperation with Russia, as the two countries align in the face of their separate, intensifying confrontations with the United States.

In January, North Korea conducted two tests of a new cruise missile designed to be launched from submarines, which leader Kim Jong Un described as a meaningful step toward his goals of building a nuclear-armed navy. The North also conducted tests of a long-range cruise missile, which it has described as nuclear-capable and can cover ranges of up to 2,000 kilometers (1,240 miles) — potentially putting U.S. military bases in Japan within reach.

> Analysts say anti-aircraft missile technology is an area where North Korea could benefit from its deepening military cooperation with Russia, as the two countries align in the face of their separate, intensifying confrontations with the United States.

Those cruise missile tests followed the Jan. 14 launch of a new solid-fuel intermediate-range missile, which underscored North Korean efforts to advance weapons that could target U.S. assets in the Pacific, including the military hub of Guam.

Friday's launches came hours after North Korean state media reported that Kim reiterated his focus on strengthening his naval forces as he inspected the construction of warships at a shipyard in Nampho on the west coast.

In recent months, Kim has emphasized efforts to build a nuclear-armed navy to counter what he portrays as growing threats posed by the United States, South Korea and Japan, which have stepped up their military cooperation in response to his nuclear ambitions.

There are concerns that Kim, emboldened by the steady advancement of his nuclear arsenal and strengthened ties with Russia, would further ramp up pressure against his rivals in an election year in the United States and South Korea. Experts say Kim's long-term goal is to force the U.S. to accept the idea of the North as a nuclear power and negotiate security concessions and sanctions relief from a position of strength.

While most analysts downplay Kim's threats of war, some say there's a possibility that he could attempt a direct military provocation in a limited scale that he can contain without letting it escalate into a full-blown war.

One of the potential crisis points is the disputed western sea boundary between the Koreas, which has been the site of several bloody naval skirmishes over the years.

Salala – A Tribute To The Flood Victims Of North Sikkim

BY MANNU SHAHI

Born on August 27, 1985, in Kalimpong, India, Bipul Chettri is one of the most well-established names in the Nepali music scene. His glorious career flaunting his magical songwriting and arranging abilities brims numerous exquisite soulful melodies.

The singer's inclination towards music brewed early as his father and grandmother were musicians and his grandfather a poet. With many creative influences at home, Bipul picked up the guitar and instantly became a regular performer at his school events. He later went on to explore western classical guitar further as a Licentiate Diploma disciple at Trinity College, London.

Debuting in the digital realms with his contagious cult-classic single 'Wildfire' (2013) on SoundCloud. The singer's discography includes two albums – "Sketches of Darjeeling" (2014) and "Maya" (2016); one EP – "Samaya" (2021); half a dozen additional singles and a few collaborations.

The musician has also garnered accolades such as the Pop Rock Album of the Year for "Sketches of Darjeeling", Best Pop Rock Composition and Best Male Pop Vocal Performance for the track 'Syndicate' at the Hero Hits FM Music Awards 2016. And since 2022, he has been elected as one of the voting members for the Recording Academy Awards (Grammys), having the authority to vote for the official nominees in selected categories to determine the winners.

Bipul's extensive live performances is enriched by his incredible



accompanying group: the Travelling Band comprising Pranai Gurung, Rahul Rai, Aman Singh Rathore, Kiran Nepali, Prince Nepali, Achint (Shivam) Khare, Binaya Man Amatya and Sonam Tashi. Together the group has toured countries including USA, UK, Canada, Japan, Australia, New Zealand, South Korea, Hong Kong, UAE, and many cities across India and Nepal.

And last Wednesday on January 31, the singer published his new single 'Salala' via his YouTube channel. Written, composed, arranged by Bipul Chettri, the song features Prince Nepali on sarangi and Binaya Man Amatya on audio mixing and mastering; recorded at Lotus Tree Studios (New Delhi) by Ritwik De and Krishna Rao. The simple yet effective video is a production of Junkeri Studio (Kalimpong); photographs by Sonam Tashi and Manohar Rai and the recorded river sound on the audio is contributed by Lhadup Moktan.

The single is dedicated to the affected families of the South Lhonak Glacial Lake Outburst occurring at North Sikkim in October 2023. The violent flood reached Teesta III Dam at midnight, destroyed the dam in minutes and further swept away scores of lives, homes, major highways, bridges and settlements affecting thousands from Sikkim to North Bengal.

The singer describes, "Salala in the Nepali language is an onomatopoeia of the sound of the river flowing. This song speaks of leaving one's home for faraway lands because of the difficulties and uncertainties of life in the hills. And so, it is filled with emotions of longing, yearning, nostalgia, wistfulness and the incurable desire to return home while being unable to. With the river Teesta being the metaphor of the only constant that keeps flowing regardless of the circumstances."

Commencing with the sound of the flowing river, Bipul joins in with his soothing minimal guitar phrasings, the video exhibits the singer alongside sarangi player Prince in a serene river bank. The live like aesthetic emitted by the minimal instrument arrangement and the video complements the mournful message this song tries to portray. The poignant sarangi counterpoints and interludes elevates the arrangement further. Admirable work on the lyrics with well-structured stanzas and intuitively articulated vocal melodies. Another gem to cherish from Bipul Chettri's creative vault!



Kris Jenner taking viewers back to the mid-2000s in her Super Bowl Oreo commercial

AP
Los Angeles, Feb. 3

The driven matriarch of the Kardashian-Jenner family will bring the phrase to the Super Bowl forefront during her commercial. She will guest star in an ad for Oreo, which will be returning to the NFL's biggest stage for the first time in a decade on Feb. 11.

"I come from a generation where it was all about the commercials for some of us," said Jenner, who will appear in her first Super Bowl ad. "I love football, but I'm not as into football as maybe some of my male friends or my kids. So it's always so exciting to wait for the commercials to come on and see what the brands would come up with. That was always embedded in my brain."

Jenner is unsure if she'll be watching the Kansas City Chiefs-San Francisco 49ers game from home or travel to Las Vegas to view in person. Either way, she'll be on the lookout with family and friends for her cameo appearance in the commercial, where she takes viewers back to the mid-2000s.

In the flashback, she's seen twisting the cookie before making the decision of taking her family into the reality television realm. It was a move that ultimately propelled them into superstardom.

"The concept was so playful, fun and really captured my quirky sense of humor," said Jenner, who played a main role in her family's first reality series "Keeping Up With the Kardashians," which launched in 2007.

In her family, Jenner said her daughter, Khloé Kardashian, came up with the concept of stacking each member's favorite cookies in a jar in their kitchen. She said her and Khloe's cookies of choice would be double-stuffed Oreos.

"I'm so excited to do this," she said. "It's so much fun. It's such a part of my family's history. We've been enjoying these cookies for decades. It's such an honor."

Hasty Pudding honors 'Saltburn' actor Barry Keoghan as its Man of the Year

AP
Cambridge, Feb. 3

Harvard University's Hasty Pudding Theatricals roasted Barry Keoghan, best known for his roles in "Dunkirk," "The Killing of a Sacred Deer," "Eternals," and "The Banshees of Inisherin," on Friday with its 2024 Man of the Year Award.

Keoghan, who also starred in the comedy psychological thriller "Saltburn" and the World War II drama series "Masters of The Air," was presented with a pudding pot before being invited to attend a performance of Hasty Pudding's 175th production "Heist Heist Baby!"

During the roast, Keoghan, who is Irish, was pressed into a boxing match with "Mr. Irish Potato Famine," played by an actor in a comically oversized suit and hat. He also participated in an awkward romantic comedy scene at the end of which he planted his face in a dish of spaghetti.

Keoghan, who acted in "The Eternals" about a race of immortal beings, confessed during the roast that his favorite Avenger was the Hulk and then changed it to Iron Man when he briefly thought Robert Downey Jr., the actor who plays Iron Man, was in the audience.

And at the end of the roast, the BAFTA award winning Keoghan was presented with a "BAFTUB" award – a bathtub-sized award that Keoghan climbed into — before being forced to don a bra adorned with cartons of Morton Salt and cardboard flames.

Wayne Kramer, co-founder of revolutionary rock band the MC5, dead at 75

AP
New York, Feb.3

Wayne Kramer, the co-founder of the protopunk Detroit band the MC5 that thrashed out such hardcore anthems as "Kick Out the Jams" and influenced everyone from the Clash to Rage Against the Machine, has died at age 75.

Kramer died Friday at Cedars-Sinai hospital in Los Angeles, according to Jason Heath, a close friend and executive director of Kramer's nonprofit Jail Guitar Doors USA. Heath said the cause of death was pancreatic cancer.

From the late 1960s to early 1970s, no band was closer to the revolutionary spirit of the time than the MC5, which featured Kramer and Fred "Sonic" Smith on guitars, Rob Tyner on vocals, Michael Davis on bass and Dennis "Machine Gun" Thompson on drums. Managed for a time by White Panther co-founder John Sinclair, they were known for their raw, uncompromising music, which they envisioned as the soundtrack for the uprising to come.

The band had little commercial success and its core lineup did not last beyond the early 1970s, but its legacy endured, both for its sound and for its fusing of music to political action. Kramer, who had a long history of legal battles and substance abuse, would tell his story in the 2018 memoir "The Hard Stuff: Dope, Crime, the MC5, and My Life of Impossibilities."



HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Your friends are likely to be on board with any idea for an adventure you cook up today. However, your own inhibitions could be a bigger obstacle. Don't be afraid to request another perspective if you truly can't tell.

TAURUS: Your mind is likely to be occupied with heavy topics at this time. Following your thoughts wherever they lead could provide you with a stronger sense of your own goals.

GEMINI: Going somewhere outside your usual routine with a loved one may give you a fresh view of your relationship. Unfortunately, you might not like everything you see.

CANCER: You might feel trapped in your daily routine. Although travel or other exciting plans may not be realistic at the moment, perhaps changing how you share responsibilities with someone else.

LEO: Emotional closeness might seem to be lacking in a current relationship of yours. Perhaps you're contributing to the problem by taking yourself too seriously.

VIRGO: You may not presently be receiving the level of care you believe you deserve from someone close to you. You might not be able to make the other person see the error of their ways.

LIBRA: Keeping your conversations overly focused on practical matters could drag you down today. Although playing it safe can help you avoid trouble, boredom can sap your energy and make you less productive.

SCORPIO: Building security could be a focus for you now. You aren't required to give in to your desire for pleasure, but don't pretend it doesn't exist. Honestly acknowledge the discomfort of sacrifice before you try to psych yourself up.

SAGITTARIUS: Your side of the story is possibly easy to tell right now. Even so, your audience may not be equipped to deliver the specific kind of validation that you're looking for.

CAPRICORN: Trying to talk things out with others could stress you out today. You may feel obligated to give people the information they're demanding from you. It's possible that factors beyond your control make this the wrong time to share.

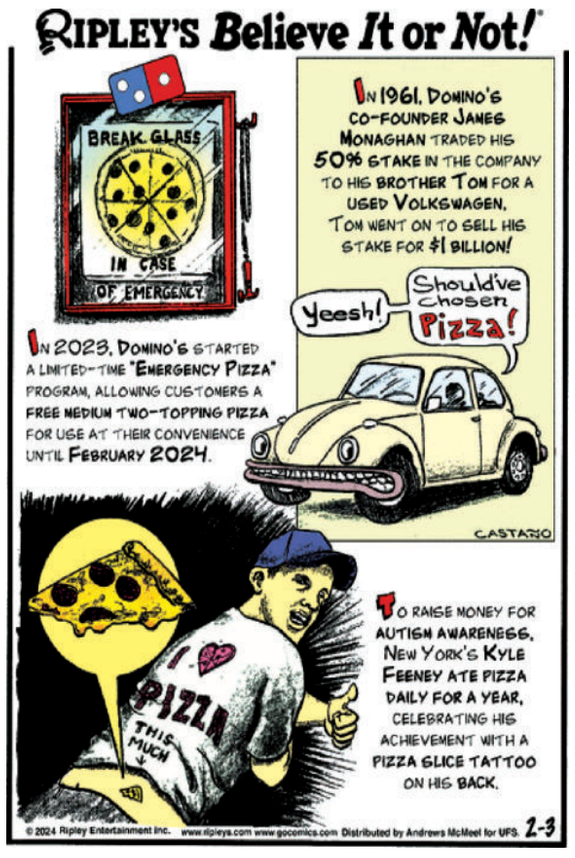
AQUARIUS: You're currently capable of steering an organisation you belong to in the way you'd like it to go. Asking openly for what you want may be more trouble than it's worth, though -- if you're anxious about that.

PISCES: Having to interact with the public could stress you out today. You may perceive your audience as demanding and protect yourself from the pressure by pulling back.

CARTOON

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Nepal Police wins 2024 PM Cup



PHOTO: BIKASH DWARE/TRN

Nepal Police Club players lift the trophy of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament 2024 defeating Tribhuwan Army Club at TU International Cricket Ground on Saturday.

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Feb. 3

Nepal Police Club was undoubtedly the best team in the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament 2024. The team made the statement echo louder by winning the tournament and lifting the trophy at the TU International Cricket Ground on Saturday.

Nepal Police Club defeated Tribhuwan Army Club by six wickets as it chased a paltry target of 182 with 73 balls remaining. It is the third tournament win for Police.

Earlier, Police and Army were declared joint winners in the first season of the PM Cup in 2017. Police won the tournament for the second time to lift the trophy alone in 2019.

This year, Nepal Police and Army qualified for the finals of the tournament, which was played in a single round-robin format, as the top two teams in the league table after playing nine matches each. Nepal Police remained undefeated throughout the league stage while Army lost two matches, against Police and Bagmati Province.

Police had defeated Army by 13 runs on January 21 while defending a low target of 141. However, Army could not defend a better target in the finals against Police.

Having given to bat first, Army started losing wickets from the 5th over as Santosh Karki (6 off 8) departed leaving the team at 13/1. Opener Imran Sheikh was at the crease until the 25th over while five other wickets fell one after another.

Bhim Sarki (5 off 8), Sandeep Rajali (0 off 5), captain Binod Bhandari (2 off 8), Kushal Malla (17 off 32) and Basir Ahamad (1 off 6) could not do enough in the middle-order. Scoring 28 off 66 balls, Imran departed with Army at 69/7.

While Police looked forward to restricting Army to less than 100 runs, Bibek Yadav said 'no'. Facing 81 deliveries, Yadav added 63 runs for Army before getting run out in the final over. Sompal Kami also contributed with 39 off 58 as Army got bundled out at 181 runs.

Lalit Rajbanshi and captain Dipendra Singh Airee took three wickets each for Police while Sagar Dhakal, Karan KC and Kushal Bhurtel bagged one each.

Army still had hoped to clinch the trophy from the undefeated Police by defending the target with some of its experienced bowlers. Nevertheless, they could not.

Sending dangerous Kushal Bhurtel (14 off 9) back to the pavilion in the final ball of his first over, Jitendra Mukhiya retired hurt after an injury to his leg. Opener Dilip Nath joined Bhurtel in the 4th over after departing at 7 off 12.

In lack of an experienced bowler, Army's Kushal Malla, Shahab Alam and Basir Ahamad bagged only one wicket each before Aarif Sheikh and Shankar Rana won the match for Police in the 38th over. Arjun Saud and Amit Shrestha also added 36 and 28 runs in the chase respectively.

While Aarif played a supportive inning, Rana played an aggressive one. Rana stayed not out at 62 runs with a strike rate of 144.18 alongside Aarif (27 off 54). The duo partnered to take the team to the win from 98/4 in 24.2 overs.

Airee and Karan KC did not have to enter the field. Rashid Khan, who has a century in the tournament this season, did not have to bat for Police as well.

Nevertheless, despite the tournament organised in the Prime Minister's name, it did not get the honour of hosting the PM in any matches, including the finals, played across three different venues. The PM was also not sighted in any of the matches of the PM Women's Cup held in December 2023.

Meanwhile, Finance Minister Prakash Sharan Mahat was seen arriving at the final match when Police had around 30 runs remaining to chase.

Individual awards

Bagmati Province's Surya Tamang was honoured as the best player of the tournament for taking 30 wickets in nine matches. He was also adjudged as the best bowler in the tournament.

Madhes Province's Anil Sah was honoured as the best batsman and the highest scorer in the tournament. He made 386 runs in nine matches with a century and two half-centuries.

Bagmati's opener Ashutosh Ghiraiya was declared as the emerging player for his two half-centuries and a century. He scored 382 runs, only four runs less than Anil, in nine matches of the tournament.

Army stuns Three Star to lift 23rd Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup



PHOTO: PHADINDRA ADHIKARI/TRN

Tribhuwan Army Club players and staff with the 23rd Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup trophy. Army defeated Three Star Club 3-0 in the finals on Saturday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 3

Playing in the finals of the Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup for the fifth time, Tribhuwan Army Club has finally won the trophy for the first time in the 23rd edition. Army defeated Three Star Club 3-0 in the finals of the 23rd Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup at Pokhara Rangasala on Saturday.

Leading 1-0 in the first half, Army added two more goals before the final whistle to make it 3-0 and defeat five-time champion Three Star. It was the seventh final for Three Star in the tournament. Gillespye Jung Karki, who was captaining the side, gave the lead to Army in the 38th minute as he scored a header on a cross from a corner kick.

Three Star's combination failed several times in the first half disallowing the team to either equalise or lead against Army. While Three Star could not score a single goal despite creating chances in the second-half, Army converted two more.

Phatteman Ghale extended the lead for Army in the 83rd minute and increased the pressure on Three Star further. As the game was about to conclude with the six-minute added time coming to an end, Basant Jimba made it 3 for Army.

Jimba scored a solo goal to snatch the game from Three Star completely in 90+4 minutes. Dribbling past Three Star defenders from outside the box, Jimba took the ball past the goalkeeper and ensured it went past the goal line.

Army's coach Meghraj KC won the Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup's title for the third time after helping Army with its first. Interestingly, in 2075 B.S., KC coached Three Star and won the trophy defeating Army in the finals. He was declared as the best coach in the tournament.

Gillespye, who was the player of the match in the finals, was also honoured as the best forward throughout the campaign while Army's Samit Shrestha was the best goalkeeper. Dinesh Henjan was the highest goal scorer in the tournament with three goals.

Army started its journey in the 23rd edition defeating Rising Star FC 1-0. Army then qualified for the quarter-finals and defeated Sankata 3-0. Latest A Division league champions Church Boys United was Army's victim in the semi-final match as the match ended 2-1.

Army's Bimal Pandey was adjudged the best player of the tournament. Army won a cash prize of Rs. 1,201,000 while Three Star departed with Rs. 601,000.

SNIPPETS

Bumrah destroys England

Vishakhapatnam (AFP): Bumrah returned figures of 6-45 and wrist spinner Kuldeep Yadav took three wickets to bowl out England for 253 as the tourists conceded a first-innings lead of 143 in Visakhapatnam. England lost wickets at regular intervals and despite a quick start courtesy Zak Crawley's 76 their innings ended in the third session after skipper Ben Stokes' 47. Bumrah got Joe Root caught at slip for five with his reverse swing and then brought the house down when he bowled first-Test hero Ollie Pope for 23 with a trademark yorker. Bumrah bowled Stokes for his 150th Test wicket with a delivery that seamed back in to the left-hand batsman and stayed low to rattle the stumps. He then registered his 10th five-wicket haul in Tests after he sent back Tom Hartley for 21 and took one more to wrap up the innings. India started batting after bundling out England at 253. In five overs before Stumps, Jaishwal and Rohit Sharma added 28 runs on the board.

Bellingham-Greenwood issue under investigation: La Liga

Barcelona (AFP): Bellingham appeared to say something to his fellow Englishman during Real Madrid's 2-0 win at Getafe on Thursday. "Getafe filed a complaint to the La Liga match director and, as is normal on these occasions, (the league) has asked for an expert lip-reading report to investigate the matter and act on the basis of what is proven," a La Liga spokesman said. Greenwood, 22, is on loan until the end of the season from Manchester United. The striker was suspended by the Premier League club in January 2022 after allegations emerged of him abusing a woman. Manchester United decided Greenwood should continue his career elsewhere following an internal investigation after charges against him were dropped in February 2023. Greenwood – capped once by England – has scored four goals in 18 league appearances for Getafe this season. Bellingham, 20, has taken La Liga by storm since he arrived from Borussia Dortmund in the summer and is the division's joint-top scorer with 14 goals.

JuJu Watkins scores USC-record 51 points

California (AP): Freshman JuJu Watkins scored a Southern California-record 51 points — the most in major NCAA women's basketball this season — and the 15th-ranked Trojans upset No. 4 Stanford 67-58 on Friday night. Watkins hit a key 3 with 3:10 remaining and four free throws over the final 18 seconds to break the previous USC scoring mark of 50 set by Cherie Nelson against California on March 11, 1989. Watkins hit six 3-pointers to help the Trojans (15-4, 5-4) send the Cardinal (19-3, 8-2) to their first home loss of the season. Watkins had 25 by halftime and finished 14 for 26 from the floor. Her 3 with 5:52 left in the third put her at 37 and USC ahead 43-35 — giving her more points than Stanford had total. Watkins came in averaging 25.8 points and Hall of Fame Stanford coach Tara VanDerveer turned to freshman Courtney Ogden to try stopping her.



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Top three winners of the KVR100 Stage Race Challenge, a 30-km race from Kathmandu's Jhule to Bhaktapur's Ranikot, organised by Trailmandu on Saturday.

Nepal Police Club shines in karate

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 3

Nepal Police Club became the champions in the three-day 3rd Krishna Prasad Bhattarai Memorial National Karate Championship with 10 gold medals. The championship ended on Saturday. Alongside the 10 golds, Nepal Police Club also secured three silvers and a bronze. Nepal Police won two golds on the final day. Biplov Lal Shrestha got a gold in the 84kg+ category defeating Sudur Pashchim's Lokesh Karki 12-4.

Shrestha is also one of the five athletes nominated for the NSJF Pulsar Sports Award. Similarly, Armed Police Force Club won three golds, five silvers and a bronze and became the runners-up of the tournament. Bagmati secured the third position with two gold, a silver and six bronze medals.

Likewise, Army won a gold, four silver and bronze medals with Sudur Pashchim bagging a gold, a silver and four bronze medals. Karnali's players were the only ones who did not win a single medal. Meanwhile, Madhes' players won a silver and six bronze, Koshi won a silver and four bronze, Lumbini won a silver and two bronze and Gandkai won a bronze.



PHOTO: TOURNAMENT ORGANISERS

Nepal Police's Biplov Lal Shrestha (left) and APF's Misli Shrestha won gold in all three editions of the tournament.

Meanwhile, Ramita Majhi and Kamal Oli were declared as the best players from the women's and men's categories respectively. Nirupa Dong and Sahil Nepali were declared as the emerging players from the women's and men's categories respectively.

Biplov Lal Shrestha, who won gold in three consecutive editions of the championship, was honoured as the superstar player. Army's Misli Shrestha was also able to win a gold medal in all three editions. The champion team, Nepal Police, also received a cash prize of Rs. 100,000 with runners-up APF getting Rs. 50,000. The tournament started on February 1.

Sri Lanka leads against Afghanistan

AP
Colombo, Feb. 3

Angelo Mathews and Dinesh Chandimal scored centuries and shared 232 runs for the fourth wicket to take Sri Lanka to a strong position in the one-off test against Afghanistan on Saturday.

Sri Lanka reached 410-6 at stumps on the second day, giving the hosts a 212-run first-innings lead at the Sinhalese Sports Club. Mathews made 141 before being hit wicket against leg spin bowler Qais Ahmed just before close. He spent nearly six hours at the crease, faced 259 deliveries and hit three sixes and 14 boundaries.

It was Mathews' 16th test hundred.

Chandimal was out earlier as the fourth wicket after scoring 107 runs off 181 deliveries for his 15th test century. He hit one six and 10 boundaries.

Their 232-run partnership took 380 deliveries and saved a potential slide after Afghanistan held Sri Lanka to 148-3 after



conceding 93 runs to the opening pair. Sri Lanka resumed on Saturday at 80 without loss in reply to Afghanistan's first innings of 198 all out, with Dimuth Karunaratne batting on 42 with Nishan Madushka on 36.

Seamer Naveed Zadran had Madushka (37) caught at leg slip by Noor Ali Zadran adding just one run to his overnight score, to have Sri Lanka at 93-1. Kusal Mendis (10) then gifted a catch to deep square leg from a bouncer by seamer Nijat Masood (1-59). Karunaratne made 77 off 72 deliveries including 12 boundaries before being caught by Ibrahim Zadran off a full toss from leg spin bowler Ahmed.

Sri Lanka captain Dhnanjaya de Silva was run out first ball after Chandimal departed caught behind by wicketkeeper Ikram Alikhil off Zadran.

Mathews swept a short ball down the leg side for a boundary only to see his bat hitting the stumps on follow-through.

Sadeera Samarawickrama was batting on 21. Zadran and Ahmed took two wickets each for Afghanistan.

Afghanistan was bowled out for 198 in its first innings on the opening day Friday with Rahmat Shah top scoring with 91 runs. This is the first test match between the two countries since Afghanistan was admitted as a test-playing nation in 2018.

WEATHER

Sunday

Sunrise at 6:49 am, Sunset at 5:46 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Sunday)

Generally cloudy throughout the country.. Light rain is likely to occur at many places of Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at some places of Gandaki Province and Lumbini Province and at a few places of Bagmati Province , at one or two places of the hilly regions of the country .. Chances of light to moderate snowfall at some places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at a few places of high hilly and mountainous regions of rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 15 - 17°C
Rain Probability: 40%

Saturday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	25.6	4.1	0.0
Dadeldhura	17.4	3.1	0.0
Dhangadi	24.4	7.5	0.0
Birendranagar	23.5	4.6	0.0
Nepalgunj	23.5	9.4	0.0
Jumla	15.9	-6.8	0.0
Ghorahi	23.3	7.3	0.0
Pokhara	21.0	7.2	0.0
Bhairahawa	21.7	8.0	0.0
Simara	21.2	5.6	0.0
Kathmandu	18.0	3.3	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.6	4.2	0.0
Taplejung	15.2	4.0	0.0
Dhankuta	20.5	6.3	0.0
Biratnagar	22.4	9.4	0.0
Jomsom	11.1	-5.0	0.0*
Dharan	22.5	9.3	0.0*
Lumle	15.7	2.8	0.0*
Janakpur	23.6	10.2	0.0*
Jiri	15.5	-2.3	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 4, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.38	Rs. 132.98
Euro	1	Rs. 144.07	Rs. 144.72
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.91	Rs. 169.68
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 154.71	Rs. 155.41
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.44	Rs. 87.84
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.97	Rs. 99.42
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.14	Rs. 99.59
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.03	Rs. 9.08
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.44	Rs. 18.53
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.30	Rs. 35.46
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.31	Rs. 36.48
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.76	Rs. 3.78
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.04	Rs. 36.20
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.07	Rs. 28.19
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.00	Rs. 10.04
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.77	Rs. 12.83
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.33	Rs. 19.42
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.93	Rs. 17.01
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.83	Rs. 432.78
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.17	Rs. 352.76

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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